

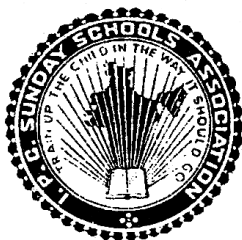
THE INDIA PENTECOSTAL CHURCH OF GOD

Sunday Schools Association

Text Book

Class 11

2020



Published by:

**IPC SUNDAY SCHOOLS ASSOCIATION
KUMBANAD**

SUNDAY SCHOOL TEXT BOOK

Class 11

Third Edition 2020

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PREFACE

Today society is blessed with the most modern innovations of technology but also burdened with curse of immorality and mental depression and no peace. Sunday schools strive to move forward in shaping up a generation that lifts up Jesus through their words and deeds as the only answer to the problems that beset us.

The truth is that the people who influenced the world with their great deeds and contributions all have come from homes that emphasized on spirituality. World-renowned evangelists, mission leaders, theologians and the like are living testimonies of those whose spiritual lives were shaped by their Sunday schools. This text book is prepared by the IPC Sunday Schools Association in its 60th year of existence keeping in mind the changes that have come about in the field of teaching. We have taken the utmost care to strictly adhere to the basic principles of the Word of God, even while bringing about changes that are reflected in the teaching style and method. This book is prepared with much prayer and detailed study of God's Word. We welcome all you fellow teachers to use this book to shape our children to be useful vessels in the Master's hands.

In the ministry of training up children, let us work together with the abundance of God's love to influence these tender minds with the Word of God so that they would be shining lights in this world that they live in.

I present this book with prayer for the glory of God so that it would be a blessing and guide to many thousands of children and families.

Your brother in Christ,

Kumbanad
04-01-2020

Bro. Kurian Joseph
Director

FOREWORD

The aim of the Sunday school is the all-round development of the spiritual, mental, and emotional faculties of our young generation. If this becomes reality, then our children who is our future will be a godly generation. Many great people who have reached the frontiers of mission have accepted Jesus into their lives in the Sunday school. Many world-renowned mission leaders, theologians, and evangelists have been part of I.P.C. because of the strong influence of the Sunday school on their lives.

There is no doubt that this textbook will increase the desire to study God's Word, help in spiritual and moral growth, and in the responsibility towards society for our young children. I request my fellow teachers to approach this textbook with prayer and meditation to prepare a generation of young people for the Lord.

We did not have a textbook that caters to nursery children in the age group of 3-5. This has become a reality. We are also very happy to announce that we are publishing textbooks with pictures and activity-based learning for the primary classes.

We express our heartfelt gratitude to everyone who has contributed immensely for this textbook that will give a bright future to our church. We hope to continue to work with you in the future.

For I.P.C. Sunday Schools Association,

Kumbanad
04-01-2020

Pastor Jose Thomas Jacob
General Secretary

INTRODUCTION

The world today is witness to revolutionary change in many spheres. Information technology has developed rapidly. But atheism, rebellion, immorality and other evils have also increased, making man's future uncertain. In this scenario, our goal is to lead our children to Christ and impart to them a spiritual vision. It was our long-standing dream to bring necessary changes in our textbooks keeping in mind the changes undergone in the field of education. We are happy that it has become a reality. Our desire is to impart the truths of the Word of God in a lucid manner to our children. We have prepared the lessons with pictures and teaching in context.

Your prayer, timely help and suggestions were useful in the past, and we hope that it will continue in the future.

We express our heartfelt gratitude and thanks to all those who helped in writing, translating, printing and publishing this book.

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LESSON 1

Book of Daniel: Historical background and Inspiration of God

Objective: To generate a liking for Bible study by learning the historical background of the prophecy of Daniel and its inspiration from God.

Lesson:

2 Kings 24:1-25:15;
2 Chro. 26:1-21;
Dan. 1:1-6

Memory verses: 2 Tim. 3:16-17

All scripture is inspired by God and profitable for teaching, for reproof, correction, and for training in righteousness, that the man of God may be complete, equipped for every good work.

Introduction

Why do we study Bible which is the Word of God? It is because the writings are inspired by God and they contain the power to transform us into men of God capable of doing good works. Let us read some familiar passages from Psalms: Psalms 19:7-11; 119:103-105. Study of the Book of Daniel which is the 27th book of the Old Testament and the Book Revelations which is the 27th book of the New Testament helps us to understand the perfection of God's plan for this world and inspire us to lead a holy life.

Historical background

This book of prophecy was written by Daniel, the beloved man of God, during the period between B.C. 606 and 534. Daniel and a few other members of the royal family along with Jehoiakim, king

of Judah were taken to Babylon as captives in B.C. 606. In B.C. 536 after 70 years, the Jewish people were granted permission by the Persian king Cyrus to return to Jerusalem and build their Temple. Daniel died in Babylon after two more years. He got most of his visions from God and wrote the book while he was in the palace of Babylon. He also got a few visions in the palace of Shushan in Elam province.

Babylon

Babel or Babylon is known as the cradle of mankind. Noah's descendants born after the great floods, occupied the plain lands near the banks of Euphrates-Tigris rivers. This area is the present day Iraq. (Draw a map of the middle east and mark the rivers Euphrates and Tigris and the cities of Babel, Shushan, Ur and Jerusalem). They built a city and tried to raise a tower reaching to the skies (Gen. 11:1-9). God confused their language and the place came to be known as Babel meaning 'confusion'. The leader who tried to build the tower was Nimrod (Gen. 10:8-10). So Nimrod is the founder of the ancient Babylon. All man-made religious practices and idol worship originated in this ancient Babylon and continue even today in different forms.

Later, Assyria which was a part of Babylon became independent and strong and Babylon began to fade away. Assyria was the powerful kingdom during the period of B.C. 885 to 607. Divided Israel with its capital Samaria was destroyed by Assyrians (2 Kings 18:10). But later in B.C. 625, King Nebopolaser of Babylon grew powerful and established a new Babylon Empire and his son Nebuchadnezzar destroyed Judah in B.C. 606.

Babylon's conquest of Jerusalem

Nebuchadnezzar conquered Jerusalem and the kingdom of Judah in B.C. 606 even before he became king. But soon he became the Emperor when his father died. He ordered Jehoiakim and members of the royal household and princes of Judah to be taken to Babylon as captives. Among them were Daniel, Hananiah, Mishaël and Azariah (2 Chro. 36:5-7; Dan. 1:1-4). The Book of

Daniel begins with the story of how these young princes stood for God and purity of life.

Nebuchadnezzar attacked Jerusalem again in B.C. 597 and took King Jehoiachin who rebelled against him, Prophet Ezekiel and many other Jews as captives to Babylon. In those days, Prophet Jeremiah continued to stay on in Jerusalem and urged the people to repent and turn to God. But King Zedekiah and others did not listen to him and persecuted him. Nebuchadnezzar attacked Jerusalem for the third time in B.C. 585. Zedekiah, the last king of Judah was defeated at that time. His sons were killed in front of him and his eyes were gauged out. He was chained and put in prison in Babylon. Later the Babylonian army took all the golden vessels from the Temple and destroyed the Temple, the palace and houses in Jerusalem. The walls around the city were also broken up (Jer. 52:11-14; 2 Chro. 36:11-20).

Why did the people who were known as the nation of God subjected to such a judgement? The reason is that they committed acts which were hated by God and persecuted prophets like Jeremiah who brought them messages from God (2 Chro. 36:14,17,18). Such a judgement was even foretold (Deut. 28:62-63; Isa. 39:5-7; Jer. 28:8-12). It is, indeed, a warning and an example to the people of God. "Do not be haughty, but fear" (Rom. 11:20).

The rise of Babylon

Babylon reached the pinnacle of its glory in the days of Nebuchadnezzar. The historian Herodotus describes Babylon as having unequalled power and glory. The wall surrounding the city was 60 miles around, 80 feet wide and 350 feet high. 6 chariots could be run in parallel on top of the wall. The river Euphrates was flowing through the middle of the city. Tall walls with 120 brass gates were built on the banks of the river. Both sections of the city were joined by a 15 feet wide, 12 feet high under-water-tunnel through the river. There was a hanging garden in the city which was considered as one of the seven wonders of the world. The palace and the temple of Baal were great examples of magnificent architecture (Dan. 4:30). The beautiful city was destroyed later

as per the prophecy of Jeremiah (Jer. 51:37,53,58). In the midst of all this splendour, Daniel shines as a bright star in the spiritual firmament. He is the perfect example of a man of God undefiled by the wickedness of this world.

The descendants of Nebuchadnezzar

Nebuchadnezzar died in B.C. 561. His descendants turned out to be pleasure loving, incompetent rulers:

1. Evil-Merodack (Nebuchadnezzar's son): B.C. 561-560 (2 Kings 25:27)
2. Neriglissar: B.C. 560-556
3. Labash-Mardack: B.C 556
4. Nebonidus (Nebuchadnezzar's son): B.C. 556-536
5. Belshazzar (Nebonidus' son): B.C. 536

When Belshazzar was ruling, Medo-Persian army under the leadership of Cyrus and Darius conquered the city and killed Belshazzar (Dan. 5: 30-31). As Cyrus was busy fighting battles to expand his kingdom, Darius, his wife's father, was ruling the kingdom for some time. But Cyrus himself took charge in B.C. 536 and proclaimed freedom to the Jews (Ezra 1:1-5). This was a fulfillment of previous prophecies (Isa. 44:28; 45:1-5). All these years, Daniel was holding high positions in the palace as advisor to various kings. He passed into glory with great hope in God, two years after the proclamation of Cyrus (Dan. 12:13).

Inspiration of God

There are many critics even in the Christian world who doubt the authorship and inspiration of the book of Daniel. But many statements are available in the book itself where Daniel refers to himself as the writer. The words "I (me), Daniel" are found in Dan. 7:1,28; 8:1; 9:2; 10:10-2; 12:2-5. Moreover, Jesus Christ, Himself, confirmed this truth (Matt. 24:15). His statement, "Therefore when you see the 'abomination of desolation' spoken of by Daniel the prophet standing in the holy place", is a clear affirmation by Jesus

Christ that the prophecy recorded in the book of Daniel (Dan. 9:27; 11:31) was revealed by God to prophet Daniel. The fulfillment of the prophecies in the book in relation to world empires and Israel confirms that the writings are inspired by God. The early church did not have any doubt about the authenticity of the book. But in the third century A.D., a man called Paulfiery expressed an opinion that the book was written by somebody else in around B.C. 168 in the days of Maccabees. But the opinion was rejected by both Jewish leaders and Christian church fathers. In modern times, too, Paulfiery's opinion is being touted as an established truth.

Jesus Christ would not have quoted from the book of Daniel if it was not an authentic revelation from God. Liberal theologians in their own pride cannot accept the miraculous incidents and prophecies recorded in the book and their historical fulfillment. Let us hope that God who humbled the proud Nebuchadnezzar will give them good sense.

Questions

1. When did Daniel live and under what circumstances?
2. What is the meaning of 'Babel'? How did that place get the name?
3. Where did man-made religious practices begin? Who was the leader at the time?
4. How many times did Nebuchadnezzar attack Jerusalem? Describe the incidents at each attack?
5. Describe the city of Babylon built by Nebuchanezzar.
6. When did Cyrus become the king of Medo-Persian empire? Under what circumstances?
7. Give evidences to show that the book of Daniel was written by Prophet Daniel and it was inspired by God.
8. Do you have a desire to study the word of God? Why?

LESSON 2

The noble qualities of Daniel

Objective: The secret of Daniel's success was his noble qualities. Likewise, we must strive to live a victorious life emulating his character.

Lesson:

Daniel
chapters 1,2,4,6,9,12

Memory verses: Dan. 12:2-3

And many of those who sleep in the dust of the earth shall awake, some to everlasting life, and some to shame and everlasting contempt. And those who are wise shall shine like the brightness of firmament; and those who turn many to righteousness, like the stars for ever and ever.

Introduction

Is it possible to live happily and victoriously in this world filled with sin, injustice and strife? Many would say, No. But what does the life of Daniel teach us, who lived in Babel (Babylon), the land of 'confusion', victoriously and as the beloved man of God? Daniel's life was blessed till the end (Dan. 6:28). While powerful kings and emperors failed miserably, how did Daniel who reached Babylon as a slave succeed? Think about it and make it your own experience.

The noble qualities of Daniel

1. Daniel was a prince and a noble man. He proved his nobility through his actions (Dan. 1:3). Those who accept Jesus Christ as their Lord are given the privilege to become sons of the Most High God (John 1:12; 1 John 3:1). Children of God must remember that they are kings and priests and live a holy and noble life (1 Pet. 2:9).

2. Daniel and his friends were very particular about keeping their identity and holiness. Although he was brought there as a slave, he decided in his heart not to defile himself with the food and drinks available in the palace and proceeded to act accordingly without fear of repercussions (Dan. 1:8). Will you fearlessly stand for purity and godliness in this wicked world? Or, will you be swayed by your friends and worldly people to imitate them? Will you take a decision now to live a separated life in the midst of this sinful generation? (1 Pet. 1:15).
3. Daniel was a humble person in front of God and the people around (Dan. 1:11,12; 10:12). God lifts up the humble (Psa. 147:6). “Yes, all of you be submissive to one another, and be clothed with humility, for ‘God resists the proud, but gives grace to the humble’. Therefore humble yourselves under the mighty hand of God, that He may exalt you in due time” (1 Pet. 5:5,6). Jesus Christ showed us the same attitude by washing the feet of His disciples (John 13:4,5; Phil. 2:8).
4. Daniel faced crises in life with prayer. Nebuchadnezzar ordered all wise men in the nation to be killed as they could not interpret his dreams. Daniel gathered his three friends and prayed for a solution all night. The same night, God revealed the meaning of king’s dream to Daniel (Dan. 2:18,19). In later years, Daniel used to fast and pray for himself and his people (Dan. 6:10-24; 9:4; 9:20). What do you do when you face a problem in life?
5. Daniel used to pray to God and confess his sins and the sins of the people. God would answer his prayers on all those occasions (Dan. 9:20). We must also confess our sins in prayer and obtain holiness in the sight of God (1 John 1:7-9).
6. Daniel was faithful in all spiritual and material affairs. Hence even his enemies could not find any fault in him (Dan. 6:4,5). We must also follow this example.
7. The most important factor in Daniel’s life was his unshakeable faith in God. He could produce the same kind of faith in the hearts of his friends and even his enemies. When he was

thrown into the den of lions, this was what King Darius asked: “Daniel, servant of the living God, has your God, whom you serve continually, been able to deliver you from the lions?” Daniel shut the mouth of lions by his faith (Dan. 6:22; Heb. 11:33,34). How wonderful is the example of putting total trust in God in adverse circumstances!

8. Daniel used to read the Scriptures diligently and understand the secrets contained in them (Dan. 9:2). Thus he could learn the plans of God for the future of his people. That was the secret by which he could shine as a brilliant, wise and strong leader (Psa. 119:99). He learned that the Babylonian captivity of Jews would end after 70 years from the Scripture passages: Jer. 25:11,12; 29:10. Will you make it a practice to read and study the Word of God regularly?
9. Daniel was filled with the Spirit of God. Heathen kings described Daniel as a person with the “Spirit of the Holy God” (Dan. 4:8,9,18; 5:11,14). Daniel had a noble heart, great wisdom and could interpret dreams because he was filled with the Holy Spirit. Filling of the Holy Spirit is essential for a victorious life.
10. Daniel possessed a blessed hope. He entered eternal rest with God’s promise: “For you shall rest, and will arise to your inheritance at the end of the days” (Dan. 12:13). He had definite assurance of the resurrection of the dead and the rewards of the righteous. “And many of those who sleep in the dust of the earth shall awake, some to everlasting life, some to shame and everlasting contempt. Those who are wise shall shine like the brightness of the firmament, and those who turn many to righteousness like the stars forever and ever” (Dan. 12:2,3). God has called us to be blessed in this life and also to shine in the life eternal. Do you have that blessed hope?

What were the special qualities of Daniel? What blessings did he receive because of those qualities? He gained great fame not only in the political realm, but also in the religious field. He is described as a holy person like Noah and Job in Ezekiel 14:14,20. Do you have a desire to live as wise and beloved children of God? How can you achieve that purpose in life? Become children of

God by faith and submit yourself in the presence of God with an earnest desire to emulate the noble qualities of Daniel.

Questions

1. What were the adverse circumstances in which Daniel lived in Babylon?
 2. What were the noble qualities of Daniel?
 3. How do we know that Daniel read the Scriptures?
 4. What do we read about Daniel in the prophecy of Ezekiel?
 5. What decisions have you taken after learning about Daniel's qualities?
 6. Make a chart listing the qualities of Daniel and write down a reference below each of them
- — — — —

LESSON 3

The special features of the Prophecy of Daniel

Objective: To understand the special features of the prophecies of Daniel and take note of the message in order to properly organize our lives.

Lesson:

Daniel chapter 12

Memory verses: Dan. 12:9,10

He said, "Go your way, Daniel, for the words are shut up and sealed until the time of the end. Many shall purify themselves, and may themselves white, and be refined; but the wicked shall do wickedly; and none of the wicked shall understand; but those who are wise shall understand."

Introduction

We have already learnt the time and circumstances in which the book was written and the special qualities of the writer. Although all the writings in the Bible are God-inspired and give spiritual edification, the books of Daniel and Revelation have some specialities. These books cannot be understood as novels or history because the writings have some mystical qualities. But those who approach the books with a sincere and prayerful attitude can certainly learn spiritual mysteries.

1. Contents

The book contains several topics beginning from the creation of man till the end times. We can find revelations in the book about the history of the world like the rise and fall of the Babylonian empire, the rise of Medo-Persian empire, the Greek empire, the Roman empire, the governments of the end times, the rule of the Anti-Christ (the Great Tribulation), etc. There are prophecies on the future of Israel (9:24-26), atoning sacrifice of the Messiah (9:26,27), resurrection of the saints (12:2,3), judgement (12:2,3) and eternal kingdom of Christ (2:24).

2. Similarities with the Book of Revelation

The Book of Daniel is the 27th book of the Old Testament and the Book of Revelations is the 27th book of the New Testament. The writer of the O.T. book is “the most beloved man, Daniel” and the writer of the N.T. book is “the most beloved disciple, John”. Both the books contain prophecies about the future. The visions and messages given by God to Daniel are from records in a book kept permanently in heaven called Jehovah’s Book (Isa. 34:16; Dan. 10:21; 12:4; 12:9,10). It may be seen from these passages that Daniel’s book is closed and sealed till the end times and can be understood only by wise men who cleanse themselves and search diligently and not by any wicked men. Compare the above verses with Rev. 22:6-9. John is instructed not to seal the prophecies of the book. The beginning of the ‘end times’ is from the Day of Pentecost when the Church was established. So we can conclude that Daniel’s prophecies are now open as they are no more sealed.

The Book of Revelation may be considered as an explanation and fulfillment of the prophecies of Daniel. The closing chapters of both the books have verses giving an indication of their special nature.

3. God's attributes as Almighty God

The 'Daniel' prophecy points to the attributes of an Almighty God through various events. Each of the chapters from 1 to 6 reveals one special attribute of God and the remaining chapters reveal God as a righteous Judge.

- i. God, the protector of His people (ch. 1): The young Jewish men Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael and Azariah were compelled to eat the food and drink the wine of the king's palace when they were being trained in Chaldean arts. They refused to do so as it was against the law of God and kept their separation and holiness. They decided to take only water and vegetables for their food. When the young men were tested after 10 days, they were found to be more healthy, beautiful, wise and clever (Dan. 1:8,12,17,20). If we keep our holiness as God's people, God will protect us and grant us health, wisdom and knowledge.
- ii. God who reveals secrets (ch. 2): Nebuchadnezzar saw a dream and the Chaldean wise men were not able to tell the dream and its meaning. The king ordered all the wise men in the land to be killed. At this crisis, Daniel and friends spent all night in prayer and God revealed to Daniel the king's dream and its meaning. God gave Daniel visions on several occasions later on and revealed to him great mysteries. If we live a spirit-filled life, we can also experience God who reveals secrets (Dan. 2:20-22).
- iii. God who saves from calamities (ch. 3): We read in this chapter the story of Hananiah (Shadrack), Mishael (Meshach) and Azariah (Abed-Nego) who were thrown into the fiery furnace for not bowing down in front of the golden idol. But God Himself ('man like the Son of God') descended into the fire and saved them. They were not

hurt in any way (Dan. 3:24-27). Nebuchadnezzar and all Babylon came to know God who will save His people from calamities (Psa. 46:1).

- iv. God who humbles the proud (ch. 4): Nebuchadnezzar boasted in his riches and power. God removed him from his throne and made him eat grass along with animals in the jungle (Dan. 4:29-33).
- v. God, the righteous judge (ch. 5): The wicked life of the proud, drunken, idol worshipping Belshazzar came to a sudden, unexpected end. The Medo-Persian kings took control of the Babylonian empire (Dan. 5:30-31)
- vi. God Almighty (ch. 6): Almighty God saved Daniel from the den of lions and His enemies were brought to shame. King Darius understood that God can close the mouth of lions and bring about signs and wonders on the earth and heaven (Dan. 6:22,26,27).

4. God, the ultimate Judge:

The word 'Daniel' means 'God is my judge'. Events described in all the chapters of the book reveal the truth that God judges people. Hence, the title 'Daniel' is most appropriate for the book.

- The first chapter describes how the judgement of God came upon His own people, Jews. As we have already studied, they were attacked three times. The nation and the city of Jerusalem were destroyed. The punishment was sent to them after clear warnings through prophets (Isa. 22:18, 19; 36:29,30; Rom. 3:19). The kings of Judah were individually punished and all the people were taken captives to Babylon. Thus began the period of the Gentiles.
- The judgement that is coming to world powers is revealed through the dream of Nebuchadnezzar in the second chapter.
- Third chapter describes the judgement that came on the tormentors of the godly young men, Hananiah, Mishael and Azariah.

- The judgement on the proud Nebuchadnezzar is given in the fourth chapter. He dreams of a great tree and according to its interpretation he becomes a mad man and is banished to the forest.
- Fifth chapter has details of the punishment of the wicked, immoral and drunken Belshazzar and the fall of Babylon. God judges the sinner.
- God fearing and blameless Daniel gets protection from God from the fury of lions, but his enemies and their families are fed to lions. Sixth chapter describes how Daniel got favour from the king as a result of these events.
- Remaining chapters from seven onwards reveal God as the righteous Judge and the King of kings of the whole world.

We learn about the glory of God and His various attributes from the study of the Book of Daniel. Our God is the King of kings and the Lord of lords. He reveals secrets to His people and protects them. He is God Almighty who topples the thrones of the proud and lifts up the humble. He is the righteous judge. Our life will be blessed if we trust Him.

Questions

1. What is the meaning of the word 'Daniel'? Explain how the title of the book matches its contents.
2. What are the similarities of the books of Daniel and Revelation?
3. Describe the attributes of God that we can learn from 'Daniel'.
4. Write briefly the topics covered in the book.
5. Give examples and show that God of Daniel reveals secrets.

LESSON 4 (For 2 periods)

The dream of Nebuchadnezzar

Objective: To learn that all the world empires will come to an end and Messiah will establish His eternal kingdom and to prepare ourselves for that kingdom in holiness.

Lesson:

Daniel chapter 2

Memory verses: Dan. 2:44,45

And in the days of those kings the God of heaven will set up a kingdom which shall never be destroyed, no its sovereignty be left to another people. It shall break in pieces all these kingdoms and bring them to an end, and it shall stand for ever; just as you saw that a stone was cut from a mountain by no human hand, and that it broke in pieces the iron, the bronze, the clay, the silver, and the gold. A great God has made non to the king what shall be hereafter. The dream is certain, and its interpretation sure.

Introduction

When we study history, we can see that world powers are not stable. Kings have lost their crowns. Big powerful empires have fallen. Democracies have crumbled leading to military rules. Political leaders live in constant fear of losing their power any time. Such situations have been predicted in the Word of God. The topic in the second chapter of Daniel is the dream of Nebuchadnezzar, the mighty emperor of Babylon and its interpretation. The future history of the nations is predicted here. After the fall of all the world powers, Messiah will establish His eternal kingdom.

The dream

Nebuchadnezzar conquered all middle east countries and became a mighty emperor. Two years after he began his rule, he saw a dream. The dream was given by God to tell him about

God's plan for the future of the world. God wished to remind the king that he need not boast about his kingdom of Babylon because it is God who is in control and He raises and removes powers of the world. Finally, Messiah will establish His eternal kingdom of earth.

Nebuchadnezzar saw a huge image standing before him in a dream. Its head was made of gold, its chest and arms of silver, its belly and thighs of bronze, its legs of iron and its feet were made partly of iron and partly of clay. As the king was watching, a stone cut out without hands flew down and struck the feet and broke the image into pieces. All the material of gold, silver, bronze, iron and clay were crushed like chaff and was carried away by wind. The stone which struck the image became a great mountain and filled the whole earth (Dan. 2:31-35).

The distress of the king

The king was greatly distressed. He lost his sleep and forgot the dream. All the wise men and magicians of the land were called to the palace and commanded to tell him both the dream and its meaning (Dan. 2:2). They told the king that no human being can tell the meaning without knowing the dream. The furious king issued orders to kill them and destroy their houses.

The mystery revealed to Daniel

When Daniel heard the news, he enquired of Arioch, the captain of the king's guard, the reason for the king's decree. Then Daniel went to the king and requested him to give some time so that he will be able to tell the king both the dream and its meaning. That night, Daniel along with his three friends knelt before God and prayed for the revelation of the dream and its meaning. The whole mystery was revealed to Daniel in a vision. The words of praises that Daniel offered to God are worth noting. He mentions seven things: "Blessed be the name of God for ever. Wisdom and might are His. He changes the times and the seasons. He removes and raises up kings. He gives wisdom to the wise and knowledge to those who have understanding. He reveals secret things. Light dwells with Him" (Dan. 2:20-22). Daniel went to Arioch and told

him not to kill the wise men of the land because he can tell the dream and its meaning to the king.

Arioch took Daniel to the king. When Nebuchadnezzar asked him whether he can tell him his dream and its meaning, the reply that Daniel gave is worth our attention: Read Dan. 2:27-30. Daniel gives all honour and glory to God and does not take any credit to himself. We can also find solutions to our problems through prayer. Let us give all honour to God.

Interpretation of the dream

The greatness and splendour of the image depicts the power and character of world powers. They appear very powerful and prosperous. But in reality they are lifeless and weak as the image. They have no strength or stability because they are standing on such a weak and dangerous mixture of iron and clay. The whole structure is made up of different materials which cannot be joined together. All the materials are taken from the earth. The nations may appear strong and bright, they are still of the earth and without any unity. The statue which begins at the top with gold and ends in feet of clay is a good picture of the world powers which appear great in the beginning but are destined to end in pieces.

Daniel explains the meaning of the four parts of the image. They represent four world powers or governments beginning with Babylon. (More details about these four powers are revealed in chapter 7).

1. Golden head:

The head represents the first world power, Babylon, that came into being after the fall of Israel. Its glory lasted 70 years from B.C. 606 – 536. Babylonian empire occupies the first place among the gentile nations. The attractive and precious gold points to the prosperity and splendour of Babylon.

Nebuchadnezzar ruled Babylon as a powerful autocrat for 44 years till B.C. 562. He spent 7 years in the wilderness with wild animals as a punishment from God for his pride (Dan. 4:30-33). His successors were weak and led lives of pleasure. Belshazzar was killed in the midst of a boisterous and drunken gathering in

his palace in B.C. 536 by Medo-Persian kings who took control of the land (Dan 5:30-31).

List of Babylonian kings is given below:

- | | |
|--------------------|----------------|
| 1. Nebopolazzer: | B.C. 625-606 |
| 2. Nebuchadnezzar: | 606-562 |
| 3. Evin Merodach | 562-560 |
| 4. Neriglizzar | 560-556 |
| 5. Lebishimarduch | 556 (9 months) |
| 6. Nebonidus | 556-536 |
| 7. Belshazzar | 536 |

(Note: Babylon is depicted as a lion with eagle's wings in ch. 7)

2. Chest and arms of silver

This part of the image points to the Medo-Persian empire which became powerful after the Babylonian empire (Dan. 2:32). The empire lasted more than 200 years from B.C. 536 till 330. As silver is inferior to gold, Medo-Persian kings had less prosperity and splendour than Babylonians, but lasted longer and controlled more areas. The picture of two hands depicts the joint authority of Medes and Persia. Gold is the symbol of kings and silver is the symbol of princes. Princes occupied positions of power in the Medo-Persian empire (Dan. 6:4,6,14,15). When they conquered Babylon in B.C. 536, Cyrus was the Persian king and his father-in-law, Darius was the Median king. As Cyrus was busily engaged with matters of war, he appointed Darius to be governor of Babylon. Two years later, when his father, Cambyses, died, Cyrus took over control of the total empire. Cyrus was succeeded by 9 kings. The empire faded away with its last king, Darius III and the Greek empire began to gain power.

(Note: The Medo-Persian empire is presented as a bear in ch. 7 and as a ram with two horns in ch. 8)

3. Belly and thighs of bronze

This part of the body of the image points to the Greek empire which became powerful from B.C. 331 (Dan. 2:39; 7:6; 8:21).

In B.C. 331, Alexander the Great conquered Medo-Persian empire and became a powerful emperor. He was very lenient to the Jews. He built cities in all lands that he conquered and tried to teach Greek language to all people. When he died unexpectedly in B.C. 323, the kingdom was divided into four. But they were still the most dominant powers of the world politically, socially and culturally until Roman empire gained in power in B.C. 63.

(Note: The Greek empire is depicted as a leopard in ch. 7 and as a male goat in ch. 8)

4. Legs of iron and feet of iron and clay

The iron legs point to the powerful Roman empire and the feet of iron and clay depict the democratic governments which come up after the fall of Roman empire.

(Note: The Roman empire is presented as a dreadful and terrible beast in ch. 7)

The Roman empire became powerful around B.C. 63. Rulers were all autocratic men from noble families. Administration was strict and without any leniency towards any one. 'Roma' was a city founded by an Italian named Romulus in B.C. 758 on the banks of River Tyber. The city rulers became very powerful later and conquered the lands around them to form an empire. An army general named Pompey who ruled from B.C. 86 to 48 subdued rebels and pirates and conquered Syria, Palestine and other middle eastern nations in B.C. 63. Pompey was killed in B.C. 48 and Julius Ceasar became the ruler. Julius Ceasar was killed by Brutus in B.C. 44. Then Octavius, Ceasar's son-in-law, Mark Antony and Lepidus ruled the empire together. In B.C. 30, Octavius took the name, Augustus Ceasar, and assumed charge as the first emperor of the Roman empire. Jesus Christ was born in Bethlehem during the reign of Augustus (Luke 2:1-7). Roman empire was divided into two: Western empire and Eastern empire in A.D. 364. The two legs of the image depict these two empires.

The feet and toes of the image represent the rulers who rise up after the fall of Roman empire. Read how Daniel describes these kingdoms: "The kingdom shall be divided. The kingdom shall

be partly strong and partly fragile. They will mingle with the seed of men, but they will not adhere to one another, just as iron does not mix with clay". See how clearly the present day democratic governments and their instability are described prophetically!

The present system of government will last till the age of the Gentiles comes to an end and will eventually lead to the formation of ten nations like the ten toes of the feet.

The stone untouched by hand and the end of the world powers: A stone untouched by hand proceeds out of the mountain and smashes the image. The stone represents none other than Jesus Christ. His birth, life, death and resurrection were all beyond human efforts. His return will also be in similar fashion. All world powers will come to an end at His glorious appearance. Christ will establish His Millennium rule on the earth.

Nebuchadnezzar fell on his face and praised God of Daniel as soon as Daniel related the dream and its interpretation to the king. Daniel was given many presents and made the chief ruler of Babylon and given authority on all the wise men of the land.

The age of the Gentiles is coming to an end and the return of Lord Jesus Christ is near. All the world powers will disappear and our Lord will establish His kingdom. Are you ready?

Questions

1. Describe the dream that Nebuchadnezzar saw in his second year of reign.
2. Which world powers do the different parts of the image point to?
3. Why do we say that the golden head represents the Babylonian empire?
4. What do the legs and feet of the image reveal?
5. Who was the founder of the Greek empire?
6. What is the period of the Medo-Persian empire?
7. What do the characteristics of gold, silver, iron and clay point to?
8. What is the solution to the instabilities that we see today in the political world?
9. Draw a map of the middle east countries and mark the rivers Euphrates and Tigris and the location of the palace of Shushan.

LESSON 5

Trials of Faith

Objective: To stand firm for faith and true worship in the face of trials.

Lesson:

Daniel : 1:6-19;
Chapter 3;
6:5-23

Memory verses: 1 Pet. 1:7-8

So that the genuineness of your faith, more precious than gold which though perishable is tested by fire, may redound to praise and glory and honor at the revelation of Jesus Christ. Without having seen him you love him; though you do not now see him you believe in him and rejoice with unutterable and exalted joy.

James 1:3,12

...for you know that the testing of your faith produces steadfastness.

Blessed is the man who endures trial, for when he has stood the test he will receive the crown of life which God has promised to those who love him.

Introduction

Have you ever faced a situation where your Christian faith has been challenged? There are many believers in our midst who have suffered persecution from their relatives and neighbours because they took water baptism after their conversion. Throughout the ages, true worshippers have faced oppositions from Satan and the world. An important message that we gather from the book of Daniel is that God extends His special care and protection to them in such situations. In these days when great forces are rising against true faith, we can derive strength from the lives of Daniel and his three friends. We shall study three incidents in this lesson.

1. Royal food

Nebuchadnezzar brought the four young men, Daniel (*Jehovah is my judge*), Hananiah (*Jehovah is gracious*), Mishael (*Who is equal to Jehovah?*) and Azariah (*Jehovah is mighty*) from Jerusalem as captives in B.C. 606. The king changed their names as the first attempt to divert them from their faith in God. They were given names related to the gods of Babylon.

Daniel : Belteshazzar meaning '*slave of Bel*'.

Hananiah : Shadrach meaning '*belonging to sun god*'.

Mishael : Meshach meaning '*belonging to goddess Shach*'.

Azariah : Abed-nego meaning '*slave of fire*'.

Then the king tried to distract them with royal food and wine. The young men decided in their hearts that they will not defile themselves with the food offered to idols and made their stand known to the king. God respected their stand and made them more attractive and healthy than other young men who ate royal food. Moreover, they became proficient in all wisdom and knowledge. Luxuries of life become snares of Satan for many. Desires of the flesh, desires of the eye and luxuries of life should not take us away from the love of God.

2. Fiery furnace

The topic in the third chapter of Daniel is the test of faith that Shadrach, Meshach and Abed-nego were subjected to after about 20 years of their captivity. Nebuchadnezzar made an image of gold, 60 cubits tall and 6 cubits broad and installed it in the plains of Dura. A great festival was organized. The king then gathered all the rulers of provinces, officials and common people of the nation and asked them to fall down before the image when horn, flute, harp, lyre etc. are sounded. It was decreed that those who do not worship the image will be cast into fiery furnace. Shadrach, Meshach and Abed-nego were also present in the gathering. (It may be assumed that Daniel was away outside the country on official business). They did not fall down and worship the image when the music sounded. The king became furious and ordered

the heat of the furnace to be increased seven times before casting the three Jewish young men into it. The young men told the king that their God was able to save them from the fiery furnace. They also added that they would never worship the king's image even if God did not save them. The furnace was so intensely hot that men who carried the three to it were consumed by fire. But the three godly young men were seen walking in the furnace unharmed along with a fourth person who looked like Son of God. The astonished king brought them out and praised them for their faith. He was convinced that their God was the only true God and declared that all the people of his nation should worship that God.

Some of the prophetic lessons associated with this incident are listed below:

1. The image's height of 60 cubits and breadth of 6 cubits do not appear to be in the right proportion. But its connection to number 6 which is man's number is quite evident. The number of the beast who will appear in future is 666 (Rev. 13:18). The image stands for the dead worship in the world.
2. All people were compelled to bow before the image. Likewise the antichrist will compel everyone during the Great Tribulation to bow before the image of the beast. The image points to the worldly tendency of worshipping man and idols.
3. The worship associated with the image was accompanied by great pomp and ceremony with sounds of horn, flute, harp, lyre etc. The festivals and worship ceremonies accompanied by bands, drums, fireworks, elephants, etc. are successors of Babylonian worship and forerunners of such ceremonies during the reign of Antichrist.
4. All those who did not bow down in front of the golden image were thrown into the fiery furnace. Similarly those who do not bow down in front of the image of the beast will be destroyed (Rev. 13:14-15).
5. Nebuchadnezzar called people of all creeds and cultures and religions to gather together in front of the image set up by him. Present day attempts at unity and cooperation among all

religions will end up in a universal religion under the leadership of the False Prophet. Thus nations and religions will come together under Antichrist and False Prophet who will lead them to Armageddon which will be a war against God (Rev. 13:11-18; 19:20).

6. The three Jewish young men who refused to worship the image represent the Jewish remnant who will refuse to bow down before the image of the Antichrist. Many Jews will be beheaded for this reason (Rev. 13:16).
7. Like the fourth person resembling Son of God who appeared in the fiery furnace to save the three young men, Christ will appear in glory to redeem the Jewish remnant (2 Thes. 2:3-8; 1:6-8; Rev. 19:19-21).

Spiritual lesson: Fiery furnace stands for sufferings (Isa. 48:10; Job 23:10; 1 Cor. 13:10). People of God may pass through experiences like the fiery furnace. In such circumstances, our Lord will come near to give grace and strength to endure those sufferings (Heb. 4:14-15). These are opportunities for us to draw closer to our Lord and for the world to see God's deliverance. We must stand firm on God's side without fearing the fiery furnace.

3. Lions' den

A great trial faced by Daniel is recorded in chapter 6. Belshazzar, the last Babylonian emperor was killed in B.C. 536 and the Medo-Persian empire was established. The Median king Darius took charge of the empire on behalf of the Persian king, Cyrus. Darius recognized Daniel as a person who held high positions in the Babylonian kingdom and made him one of the three top rulers in his kingdom. Probably Darius heard about what Daniel had told Belsazzar about the fall of the Babylonian empire. Daniel's reputation was great at that time when he was more than 86 years old. He continued to be a great ruler even in the Medo-Persian empire. There were many jealous colleagues who wanted to find some faults in Daniel's way of administration. Let this be an example for us, believers, to be honest and upright if we happen to be in positions of power.

Enemies of Daniel influenced Darius to bring out an order designed to put him down. The order proclaimed that for 30 days every one should pray only to the king and if a person is found praying to any man or god other than the king, he will be cast into a den of lions. But Daniel was not frightened by the order. He continued to kneel down and pray to God as usual three times a day. The king was informed about this. Although he wanted to save Daniel, he could not go against the wishes of his officials and he ordered that Daniel be cast into the lions' den. Next day morning, the king reached the entrance of the den and found that Daniel was unhurt. Darius brought Daniel out of the den and ordered his enemies to be cast into it instead. By this incident Darius came to know the power of God and gave all glory and honour to Him.

Let Daniel's life be an example to us. He gave more value to his relationship with God than to his high position in the world. As children of God attain greater positions of power or status in this world, they are likely to face bigger trials of faith. God allows tests in our life, not to destroy us, but to see us come out of them victorious. In all this, God's name should be glorified. In the midst of his trials, Job declared: "when he has tested me, I will come forth as gold" (Job 23:10).

We have learnt about three tests that Daniel and his friends passed through. Whether we are in attractive surroundings or in the midst of sufferings or in the den of lions, we should never waiver from our close and pure relationship with our Lord. In these days when top spiritual leaders are being swayed by riches and power, let us commit our lives to a close walk with our Lord.

Questions

1. Have you ever had any experience when your faith in God was tested? Describe the experience if any.
2. Give names of the four Jewish young men in the book of Daniel. What are the names given to them by Nebuchadnezzar? Write the meanings of all the names.
3. What was the purpose of Nebuchadnezzar in changing their names and asking them to eat royal food?

4. Why did the young men refuse to eat the royal food and drink royal wine?
 5. Describe the golden image set up by Nebuchadnezzar in the plains of Dura. What is the prophetic significance of the image?
 6. What is the meaning of fiery furnace? Why does God allow His children to go through experiences of the fiery furnace in their life?
 7. What do the young men and the fourth person in the furnace represent prophetically?
 8. Describe the circumstances in which Daniel was cast into the den of lions.
 9. Quote the verses that Apostle Peter mentions regarding trial of faith.
 10. Recite James 1:3-4, 12.
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LESSON 6

God's Judgement

Objective: To learn that God's judgements are just and to lead a holy life with fear.

Lesson:

Daniel
chapter
4 & 5

Memory verses: Dan. 4:37

Now I, Nebuchadnezzar, praise and extol and honor the king of heaven; for all his works are right and his ways are just; and those who walk in pride he is able to abase.

Psa. 58:11

Men will say, "Surely there is a reward for righteous; surely there is a God who judges on earth"

Introduction

It is very comforting to know that God is love (1 John 4:8). It is also a fact that God is a just judge (Psa. 7:11). This message comes out strongly from the book of Daniel.

Chapter 4 describes how the proud Nebuchadnezzar was brought down from his throne and made to live with wild animals

and eat grass like an ox. Chapter 5 describes how the immoral, drunken, idol worshipping Belshazzar was killed suddenly and his kingdom taken away by Medo-Persian army. It is surely justice that sin should be punished.

Nebuchadnezzar's dream

God revealed His glory and power to Nebuchadnezzar through his first dream and the deliverance of Shadrack, Meshack and Abednego from the fiery furnace. As many people disregard revelations and live without reverence and thankfulness to God, Nebuchadnezzar lived a proud and careless life without any fear of God (Rom. 1:20-21).

Under these circumstances, God warned him through another dream.

The dream

Read Dan. 4:10-17. The king saw a tree growing tall and strong in the middle of the earth and reaching up to heaven. Birds fed on the fruits of the tree and wild animals rested under its shadow. The king saw an angel coming down from heaven and saying:

“Hew down the tree and cut off its branches. — Leave the stump in the earth and let it be wet with the dew of heaven. — Let his heart be changed from man's, and let a beast's heart be given unto him and let seven times pass over him”.

Meaning of the dream

As the wise men of Babylon could not interpret his dream, the king summoned Daniel to his presence. Daniel was stunned when he heard the dream. He understood the meaning and told it to the king. The tall, strong tree represents the king who has become powerful and rich and exalted. The branches of the tree point to the nations in his control, the leaves point to his military strength and the fruits represent the richness of the kingdom. The birds in the branches and the wild beasts in the shadow point to the beastly and immoral life style prevailing in the kingdom. As the tree was cut down, Nebuchadnezzar will lose his throne. He will also lose

his mental powers and will live like an animal in the forest for seven years. All his servants will be scattered, but his stump will not be uprooted. He will be restored to power when he understands that God Almighty rules over his throne and humbles himself (Dan. 4:20-26).

Daniel rightly utilized the opportunity to advise the king to leave his wayward ways and humble himself before God, but the king did not listen to his advice.

After twelve months, one day, Nebuchadnezzar was walking in his palace and telling to himself: "Is not this great Babylon, that I have built for the house of the kingdom by the might of my power, and for the honour of my majesty?" Immediately there was a voice from heaven: "O king Nebuchadnezzar, to thee it is spoken; The kingdom is departed from thee. And they shall drive thee from men, and thy dwelling shall be with the beasts of the field: they shall make thee to eat grass as oxen, and seven times shall pass over thee, until thou know that the most High ruleth in the kingdom of men, and giveth it to whomsoever he will". The words came to pass immediately. Nebuchadnezzar left the palace as a mad man and lived in the forest with animals for 'seven times'. ('Seven times' could be considered as seven years. But there are some who think that it could be three and a half years because in one year, there are two times or seasons: winter and summer). After the stipulated time, the king got back his senses when he humbled himself and lifted up his eyes towards heaven. He was restored to his throne. He declared: "Now I Nebuchadnezzar praise and extol and honour the King of heaven, all whose works are truth, and his ways judgment: and those that walk in pride he is able to abase"

The feast of Belshazzar:

Nebonidus, Nebuchadnezzar's son by his second wife, became king in B.C. 555. But as he was leading a leisurely life outside the capital city, his son, Belshazzar was ruling the country in his place. Daniel ch. 5 begins with a great feast and ends in calamity. Belshazzar prepared a great feast for 1000 noble men

of his kingdom. He, his wives and his concubines began to drink wine in the golden and silver vessels which Nebuchadnezzar brought from the Temple in Jerusalem in front of all people and to praise his gods made of gold, silver, brass, iron, wood and stone. At that time, a man's hand appeared and wrote some words on the wall. Belshazzar was frightened. The wise men of Babylon could not read or interpret the writing on the wall. Then Daniel, known to all people as a man with the spirit of God, was brought in and he read the words and interpreted them. The writing was "Mene, mene, tekel, upharsin" which meant: "God hath numbered thy kingdom and finished it. Thou art weighed in the balances and art found wanting. Thy kingdom is divided and given to the Medes and Persians" (Dan. 5:26-27). Belshazzar was killed in the same night and his kingdom was captured by Medes and Persians. This happened as a fulfillment of the prophecies about Babylon and the Persian king, Cyrus recorded many years earlier (Jer. 51 :6-8; Isa. 45:1-3).

Spiritual lessons

The story about Belshazzar contains many spiritual lessons.

1. The feast of Belshazzar stands for the natural man's enmity with God, his tendency for lustful merry making, his thoughtlessness and unholy character. The story points to the sudden destruction that befalls those who indulge in lustful celebrations. Remember what happened in the days of Lot and Noah. The wrath of God's judgement will certainly fall on those who waste their lives in such lustful ways.
2. Belshazzar did not invite Daniel to his feast. Even if he was invited, he would not have participated in the feast. Children of God should never participate in such drunken feasts.
3. Programs during such feasts are such that they lead the participants to commit more sins, more drunkenness, more immoral acts and more idolatry. Belshazzar was tempted to use even the holy vessels of the Temple to indulge more in his drunken behaviour.

4. The writing on the wall was the judgement of God. Belshazzar lost his balance, the joints of his loins loosened and his knees knocked against each other. All his guests were frightened. Celebration turned into fright. No wicked person will be able to stand in front of the judgement of God.
5. The incident exposes the inadequacy of worldly wisdom. The wise men of Babylon could not understand the writing on the wall. Worldly wise men do not understand the judgement of God. The Scripture says: "For this they willingly are ignorant of, that by the word of God the heavens were of old, and the earth standing out of the water and in the water: Whereby the world that then was, being overflowed with water, perished: But the heavens and the earth, which are now, by the same word are kept in store, reserved unto fire against the day of judgment and perdition of ungodly men" (2 Pet. 3:5-7). Man cannot escape from God's judgement by his own merits. God's judgement is that a man who sins will die and He has provided a way of salvation through Jesus Christ. "He that believeth on him is not condemned" (John 3:18). "There is therefore now no condemnation to them which are in Christ Jesus, who walk not after the flesh, but after the Spirit" (Rom. 8: 1). Have you received deliverance from condemnation? If not, receive Jesus Christ as your Lord and Saviour now.

Questions

1. Bible says that God revealed Himself to Nebuchadnezzar three times. When and how? .
2. Describe the tree that the king saw in his dream.
3. a) Explain the meaning of the dream.
4. b) What lesson did God teach through the dream?
5. a) Describe the feast prepared by Belshazzar
- b) What was the writing on the wall and its meaning?
6. Prove that God is a just judge citing the incidents in the lives of Nebuchadnezzar and Belshazzar.
7. What are the spiritual lessons that we learn from the writing on the wall at the time of Belshazzar's feast?

LESSON 7

Four great beasts

Objective: To understand that world empires are cruel and terrible like wild beasts and look for the eternal, righteous and peaceful kingdom of God.

Lesson:

Daniel chapters 2 & 7

Memory verses:

Dan. 7:27

And the kingdom and the dominion and the greatness of the kingdoms under the all heaven shall be given to the people of the saints of the Most High; their kingdoms shall be an everlasting kingdom, and all dominions shall serve and obey them.

Psa. 145:13

Thy kingdom is an everlasting kingdom, an that dominion endures throughout all generations.

Introduction

In which direction is this world moving? This is a question that is worrying political leaders and philosophers. But the future of the world is clearly forecast in the Word of God. Look back to Nebuchadnezzar's dream described in Daniel ch. 2. What are the main parts of the image in the dream? What materials are they made of? Which empire does each of them represent? The first six chapters in the book describe the visions and dreams of gentile kings and their interpretations given by Daniel. Ch. 7 onwards describe the visions of Daniel himself. Their meanings are interpreted to him by a mighty angel. Ch. 7 contains Daniel's vision about world empires.

Description of the dream

Four diverse beasts came up from the great sea (Mediterranean sea) when four winds blew upon it from four directions. The first beast appeared like a lion with eagle's wings.

As Daniel was looking, its wings came off and the beast stood up like a man. The second beast looked like a bear. It was holding three ribs in the mouth between its teeth. The beast was commanded to eat much flesh. The third beast was like a leopard. It had four heads and four wings. It was given dominion. The fourth beast was different from the others. It was dreadful and terrible and had big iron teeth. It devoured and destroyed and had ten horns. As Daniel was watching, a little horn came up in the midst of other horns and three of the old horns were uprooted. The little horn had the eyes like man's eyes and a mouth speaking great things. Then the Ancient of Days sat on the judgement throne and books were open. The beast was killed because of the big sound of the words spoken by the horn and its body was consumed by fire. Daniel saw the Son of Man coming in the clouds of heaven and establishing an everlasting kingdom.

Meaning of the dream

The four beasts represent four empires which had dominion around the Mediterranean sea. Nebuchadnezzar's dream pointed to the external nature of the four world empires. But Daniel got the vision of their inner character. The beasts show the destroying nature of the empires. They kill and consume. World kingdoms cannot provide good and peaceful governance because of their violent nature. Prophecies about the empires were literally fulfilled. Nebuchadnezzar's image and Daniel's beasts represent the same world empires. While the gentile king sees the outward glory of the empires, Daniel, the man of God, finds them cruel and destructive.

1. Lion: The beast like a lion and with wings of eagle is Babylonian empire. It is the same as the golden head of the image in Nebuchadnezzar's dream. The beast stands for the pride, glory and cruelty of the empire. The eagle's wings point to the speed

with which Nebuchadnezzar's army moved. The loss of wings show how the army became weak when the conqueror, Nebuchadnezzar turned mad. The fall of Babylon after 70 years of power and glory was prophesied by Isaiah and Jeremiah (Isa. 13:1-22; 45:1-3; Jer. 51:36-39).

2. Bear: This beast point to the Medo-Persian empire represented by the silver chest and hands of Nebuchadnezzar's image. (This kingdom is also depicted as a ram with two horns in ch. 8). Although this empire was not as glorious and powerful as Babylon, it was no less cruel or fierce. The number of people that this empire killed is beyond description. The command, 'Get up and eat the flesh' summarizes the cruelties of this empire. One side of the bear was seen as higher than the other. This appearance points to the higher status that the Persians enjoyed in the joint rule. The three ribs in the mouth of the beast represent Babylon, Libya and Egypt which were captured by Medo-Persians. As the Persian king Cyrus showed kindness to Israel, God allowed the empire to remain power for more than 200 years from B.C. 536 – 331 (Heb. 1:1-4). The army of Alexander defeated the Medo-Persian army in B.C. 331. List of Medo-Persian kings are given below:

1.	Median king, Darius	-	B.C. 538-536
2.	Persian king, Cyrus	-	538-530
3.	Artaxerxes	-	530-522
4.	Darius	-	522-486
5.	Xerxes (Ahashwerus)	-	486-465
6.	Artaxerxes I	-	465-423
7.	Darius II	-	423-404
8.	Artaxerxes II	-	404-359
9.	Artaxerxes III	-	338-335
10.	Arxes	-	338-335
11.	Darius III	-	335-331

3. Leopard: The brass belly and thighs of Nebuchadnezzar's image is pictured as leopard in Daniel's vision and point to the Greek empire. The same empire is pictured in ch. 8 as a rough goat with a horn between its eyes representing the first emperor Alexander. (Read Dan. 8:21). Even though brass is less valuable than gold and silver, it is quite stronger than them. In a similar fashion, leopard is quite powerful and violent in nature as compared to lion and bear. The wings on the back of the leopard show the speed with which Alexander conquered other nations. He conquered all the then-known nations in the short span of 13 years. The beauty of the leopard represent the high level of Greek culture. The spots on its body point to the different groups of people in the Greek empire. The leopard had four heads and four wings. The empire was divided into four kingdoms after the death of Alexander. The same occurrence is predicted in ch. 8 as four horns appearing in the place of one on the head of the goat (8:22). The Greek empire lasted for about 180 years from B.C. 330 to 150. The following four divisions came into being after Alexander:

- | | |
|----------------------|-----------------|
| 1. Asia Minor | Under Lecimacus |
| 2. Macedon (Greece): | Under Cassandra |
| 3. Egypt: | Under Ptolemy |
| 4. Syria: | Under Celucius |

Palestine was under Syria in the beginning. Later in B.C. 301, it came under Egypt's rule. Under Egyptian rule, Jews lived quite peacefully. In B.C. 198, Syrian ruler Antiochus conquered Palestine and brought it under him. Antiochus Epiphanus who ruled Syria from B.C. 175 to 164 desecrated the Temple in Jerusalem and destroyed the city. He stands as a shadow of Antichrist.

4. The dreadful and terrible beast: The unnamed fourth beast symbolizes the Roman empire. We have already learnt that the iron legs and the iron/clay mixed feet of Nebuchadnezzar's image stand for the Roman empire and the democratic governments that follow it. The iron teeth of the beast show the power of the Roman empire. Iron/clay mixture is the mixture of autocratic and

democratic rules. Roman government was such a mixed type. The empire which came into power in B.C. 150 grew stronger and conquered Jerusalem in B.C. 63. The earthly ministry of Jesus happened when the Romans were ruling. The Romans became most powerful by first century A.D. The empire was divided into two as Western empire and Eastern empire in the fourth century. The Western empire ceased to exist in the fifth century. The Eastern empire continued in power till A.D. 1453 when Ottoman (Turkey) empire conquered Constantinople and converted the famous Sophia cathedral into a muslim mosque. The ten horns of the beast and the ten toes of the feet of the image represent the nations that followed the Roman empire. Book of Revelation describes how a ten horned beast will emerge out of the sea of humanity and how it will be destroyed by Jesus Christ who will establish His kingdom (Rev. 13:1-2). The beast points to the emergence of Antichrist. "And another shall rise after them" in Dan. 7:24 is a reference to Antichrist. After he is destroyed, kingdom and dominion will be with "the saints of the most high" (Dan. 7:27).

All the world empires and finally Antichrist will be subjected to the judgement of God and come to an end. Let us wait earnestly for an everlasting kingdom.

Questions

1. Describe the vision that Daniel saw about the future of world empires.
2. Describe the significance of each animal in the vision.
3. Are you preparing yourself for the establishment of the everlasting kingdom of Jesus Christ?
4. Draw pictures of the four beasts in Daniel's vision according to their descriptions found in Daniel 7.
5. Compare the dreams in chapters 2 and 7.

LESSON 8

A ram and a goat

Objective: To learn that plans of kings of the earth are futile because their kingdoms will perish at appointed times and the kingdom of God will finally be established.

Lesson:

Daniel chapter 8

Memory verses:

Dan. 8:19-21

He said, "Behold, I will make known to you what shall be at the latter end of the indignation; for it pertains to the appointed time of the end. As for the ram which you saw with the two horns, these are the kings of Media and Persia. And the hegoat is the king of Greece; and the great horn between his eyes is the first king.

Psa. 2:1-2

Why do the nations conspire, and the peoples plot in vain?

The kings of the earth set themselves, and the rulers take counsel together, against the Lord and his anointed, sayings,

Introduction

History records the rise and fall of nations in the world. Book of Daniel contains many historical events and important prophecies concerning them. Ch. 8 describes the continuation and culmination of prophetic predictions made in chs. 2 & 7.

The vision

Daniel was in the palace of Shushan in the province of Elam in the third year of the reign of Belshazzar when he saw a vision. He found himself standing by the river of Ulai and there appeared a ram with two long horns. One horn was longer than the other. The ram pushed westwards, northwards and southwards. No beast could stand against it and it did as it pleased. As Daniel was watching, a goat came from the west without touching the ground. The goat had a notable horn between the eyes. It came to the ram with great fury and broke its two horns. It cast down the ram to the ground and stamped it under its feet. The goat became very great and strong. As it became great, its notable horn got broken and in its place four horns grew up. A small horn came out of one of the four horns and grew into a big one even reaching upto the host of heaven. It stopped daily sacrifices and destroyed the holy sanctuary. Then Daniel heard one saint speaking to another: "How long will this transgression last?" The answer was: "Two thousand three hundred days. After that period, the sanctuary will be restored".

As Daniel was thinking about the meaning of the vision, Angel Gabriel came to him and explained the meaning to him.

Ram with two horns

The animal points to Medo-Persian empire. The longer horn represents the Persian kings who were stronger than the Medians. It is a historical fact that as the ram was seen pushing in three directions, this empire extended its reign from India to Ethiopia.

Goat

The conquering goat represents the Greek army and the horn between its eyes represents Alexander the Great. The army of Alexander conquered all the then known nations of the world very speedily. Greek army defeated the Persians in two stages, first in B.C. 334 and then in B.C. 331. The two attacks are pictured in the vision. In the first step, both horns of the ram were broken and in the second stage, the ram was trodden on the ground. Just when

the goat was becoming stronger, its horn was broken. Alexander was returning after conquering nations upto India, he got drunk and spent one night in a river. He became seriously sick and suddenly died at the age of 33 in B.C. 323. A great warrior who conquered all nations in 12 short years was himself struck down by alcohol! How many great men are conquered by the alcohol monster even today!!

Four horns

Four new horns came up when the single horn of the goat was broken. (You may recall that the leopard in ch. 7 had four heads). The new horns show the division of the Greek empire into four after the death of Alexander. The divided nations were Macedon, Asia, Egypt and Syria which remained in power till B.C. 150 and propagated the Greek language and culture. Of these, Egypt and Syria were always in conflict with each other for many years.

Small horn

A small horn sprouted out of one of the four horns. It became very strong "towards south, east and the pleasant land" (Dan. 8:9). Who does this horn represent? Gabriel explained thus: "When the transgressors are come to the full, a king of fierce countenance and dark sentences, shall stand up. And his power shall be mighty" (Dan. 8:23). His actions are described in Dan. 8:10-12; 8:24-25. The king referred to could be Antiochus Ehippanus, an autocratic ruler who attacked Jerusalem in second century B.C., stopped all sacrifices in the Temple and killed many Jews. He is also a shadow of Antichrist who will rise up after the first phase of the second coming of Jesus Christ (when His saints will be raptured) and rule the world in a cruel and despotic manner.

Two thousand three hundred days

How long will the atrocities of this king last? The answer given in Dan. 8:14 is 2300 days. Historians say that the fearsome rule of Antiochus Ehippanus lasted for 2300 days. But there is also another prophetic implication of this period. Daniel 9 speaks of a

coming prince who will “confirm the covenant for one week and cause the sacrifice to cease in the middle of the week” (Dan. 9:27). Prophetically one week represents 7 years of 360 days each, meaning 2520 days. Persecution of the Jews and restriction on their worship will start at the beginning of this period and intensify after 220 days when the period of 2300 days begins. After another 1040 days in the middle of the week, persecution will become very fierce for the next 1260 days. At the end of this great tribulation, our Lord Jesus Christ will appear in glory to destroy Antichrist and establish His kingdom. Let us be ready for that beautiful morning

Questions

1. Describe the vision mentioned in Dan. 8.
2. What is the significance of the ram with two horns?
3. Explain how the prophecy about the ram and its horns was fulfilled historically?
4. Explain from history the meaning and fulfillment of the single horn of the goat.
5. Describe the events symbolized by the four horns which came up after the breaking of the single horn.
6. Who does the small horn which came out of one of the horns of the goat represent? How was the prophecy fulfilled in history? What future event does it foretell?
7. How is the period of 2300 days in the vision connected with the ‘one week’ of Antichrist?

LESSON 9

The prayer of Daniel

Objective: To be encouraged by the example of Daniel's prayer life and put it into practice in our life.

Lesson:

Daniel
Chapters
9 & 10

Memory verses:

Dan. 9:4-5, 18

I pray to the Lord and my God and made confession, saying, "O Lord, the great and terrible God, who keepest covenant and steadfast love with those who love him and keep his commandments, we have sinned and done wrong and acted wickedly and rebelled, turning aside from thy commandments and ordinances.

O my God, incline thy ear and hear; open thy eyes and behold our desolations, and sitting which is called by thy name; for we do not present our supplications before thee on the ground of our righteousness, but on the ground of thy great mercy.

Col. 4:2

Continue steadfastly in prayer, being watchful in it with thanks giving;

Introduction

What was the secret of success in the life of Daniel? He achieved commendable success in living a holy life, faced trials courageously without wavering, received divine visions and revelations and exalted the name of the living God in front of Gentile kings - all because of his prayer life. Is your Christian life a success? If not, what is the reason? Let us examine our standing in the light of Daniel's experiences.

1. The necessity of prayer:

- a) God created man with a glorious purpose. God wanted man to be a partner in His life and nature and live a happy life in fellowship with Him. But man became separated from God and started living a selfcentered life because of his disobedience of God's command. Man came under sin and death and lost his happiness and power. We can now be reconciled to God only by the atoning sacrifice of Jesus Christ. We "who were far off are made nigh by the blood of Christ". We get the privilege to call God, Abba, Father. It is the responsibility of such privileged people to keep communion with God through prayer. Daniel used his privilege very rightly and without fail. Hence God called him, "man, greatly beloved" and talked with him.
- b) Man is God's creation. He has spiritual, mental and material needs. Jesus told His beloved disciples: "without me ye can do nothing" (John 15:5). Daniel knew very well of his nothingness. Hence prayer became an integral part of his life. In his prayer recorded in Dan. 9:4-10, he was placing his own needs and the needs of his people in the presence of God.
- c) Surely, our God knows all our needs. But we express our dependence and trust in God through our prayers. We see that in the prayer of Daniel (Dan. 9:14,18).
- d) God desires that His children place their needs before Him with thanksgiving (Matt. 7:7; Phil. 4:6). God has promised that He will hear our prayers and answer them (John 16:24-25). Daniel placed his needs before God with thanksgiving (Dan. 9:17). He saw his prayer answered in his own life time when Cyrus, the Persian king, issued the order to restore Jerusalem and the Temple.
- e) Prayer is the solution to despair. Circumstances in the life of Daniel should have normally driven him to despair. When orders were issued to kill all wise men of Babylon as they failed to interpret Nebuchadnezzar's dream and when he

was put in the lions' den for not worshipping the Median king Darius, Daniel was not frightened or disappointed because he was a man of prayer.

2. The special nature of Daniel's prayer:

We need to study the prayer of Daniel very carefully. We can learn many important lessons that we ought to remember for a life of prayer.

- a) Daniel started his prayer after meditating on the Word of God (Dan. 9:2-3). He read the scroll of the prophecy of Jeremiah. From Jeremiah's prophecy, he learnt that the desolation of Jerusalem will end after 70 years. There are many promises and prophecies about the future in the Word of God. We will come to know of how and what we should pray by meditating on the Scriptures. The Word of God will help in renewing our hope and reminding us about God's provisions for us.
- b) Daniel reiterates the greatness and exalted nature of God while praying (Dan. 9:4). When we approach God, we must be fully aware of our God's greatness. He is faithful and full of mercy. He loves us and desires to bless us with good things. At the same time, we must be conscious of His holiness, power and glory.
- c) Daniel understands the reason for the bad situation in which he and his people are currently placed. He confesses to God that they are in Babylonian captivity because of their sins (Dan. 9:5-13). When we pray for deliverance from our problems, we must find out the reason for the situation and confess to God of our sins.
- d) Daniel prayed after asking forgiveness of his sins and the sins of his people (Dan. 9:5-6, 11-15, 19, 20). Then God sends Gabriel to Daniel with a message. Consider how we pray. Do we pray like the Pharisee boasting about ourselves? Daniel trusted on the mercy of God and not on his own goodness (Dan. 9:18). "If we say that we have no

sin, we deceive ourselves and the truth is not in us. If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness” (1 John 1:8-9). He who confesses his transgressions and forsakes them will receive mercy. We receive forgiveness of sins through Jesus Christ (Dan. 9:17; 1 John 2:12).

- e) Another feature of Daniel’s prayer is his stress on the authority of God in everything. Note the expressions like ‘your people’, ‘your holy mountain of Jerusalem’ and ‘your holy temple’.
- f) Gabriel arrived with God’s message while Daniel was praying at the time of the evening sacrifice in Jerusalem (Dan. 9:21). Even at his old age, he did not forget the times of sacrifices although in those days, there was no worship or sacrifice in Jerusalem. Moreover, it was his regular practice to kneel down and pray three times every day (Dan. 6:10). We can learn the importance of setting apart specific times for prayer and worship. Also, let us not forget the apostle’s instruction of “not forsaking the assembling of ourselves together” (Heb. 10:24).
- g) Daniel humbled himself before God when he prayed (Dan. 10:12). People of God get answers to their prayers when they humble themselves and seek God’s face (2 Chron. 7:14).
- h) Daniel’s strength was in his unwavering faith in God. His deliverance from the den of lions was an example of his faith (Dan. 6:23).
- i) Daniel spent several days in fasting and prayer before God (Dan. 10:2-4). He teaches us the need for fasting and prayer for days or weeks to receive revelations from God and solutions to our problems. Our Lord Jesus and apostles have set us examples in this aspect (Matt. 4:2; Acts 13:2). The main purpose is to achieve victory over the forces of the devil (Dan. 10:12-13; Matt. 4:1-3; 17:21).

The answer to prayer:

The book of Daniel reveals the truth that God hears and answers prayer. Daniel and his three friends prayed for the interpretation of Nebuchanezzar's dream and they got the answer in the same night (Dan. 2:18,19). Daniel prayed to know the time of deliverance of his people from Babylonian captivity. But in answer to his prayer, God revealed all the events that would happen till the establishment of Messiah's kingdom on earth. Glory be to God who is "able to do exceeding abundantly above all that we ask or think" (Eph. 3:20).

We have learnt that the secret of Daniel's victory was his life of prayer. Shall we make a decision now to follow his example?

Questions:

1. Prove from the experiences of Daniel that prayer should be an important factor in the life of children of God.
2. Describe the special features of the prayer of Daniel.
3. Prayer is a privilege of God's children. Why?
4. We should read and meditate on the Word of God before prayer. Why?
5. What is the objective of fasting and prayer?
6. Which are the things that we should remember when we pray for deliverance from our problems?
7. Prove that God hears prayers, from the experiences of Daniel.

LESSON 10

Seventy weeks

Objective: To learn about the wondrous nature of God's plan regarding the redemption of this earth and the restoration of Israel and be ready to meet our Lord at His second coming.

Lesson:

Daniel 9:20-27

Memory verses:

Dan. 9:24

“Seventy weeks of years are decreed concerning your people and your holy city, to finish the transgression, to put an end to sin, and to atone form iniquity, to bring in everlasting righteousness, to seal both vision and prophet, and to anoint a most holy place.”

Introduction

What was the great desire of Daniel and his people who were captives in Babylon? What truth did Daniel learn from the prophecy of Jeremiah? When Daniel learnt that the captivity of Israel would end in 70 years, he thanked God and prayed for forgiveness of his sins and the sins of his people. Then Gabriel came to him with the message from God, revealing God's plan for man till Messiah establishes His kingdom on earth. Gabriel showed Daniel the mystery of the 'seventy sevens' (seventy weeks) set for the purification and restoration of Israel. This is an important prophecy concerning the people of Israel.

Explanation of the prophecy:

The prophecy about the “seventy weeks” is recorded in Dan. 9:24-27. Read the passage carefully. It is necessary to explain the meaning of “seventy weeks” to understand the prophecy clearly.

“Seventy weeks”

‘Seventy weeks’ is also referred to as ‘seventy sevens’. One week represents a period of seven years. Therefore ‘seventy weeks’ represents a period of 490 (70×7) years. This period of time has been set “to finish the transgression, and to make an end of sins, and to make reconciliation for iniquity and to bring in everlasting righteousness”. This period is specifically connected with the people of Israel.

‘Seventy sevens’ in the history of Israel

We can observe groups of 490 years throughout the history of Israel. Their years of disobedience with God’s anger dwelling on them are counted as wasted years in their history and hence ignored in the accounting.

1. From the call of Abraham (BC 1011) till the exodus of Israel from Egypt (BC 1606) was 505 years. Ishmael (‘son of flesh’) stayed in Abraham’s house for 15 years. If we remove 15 years from 505 years, we get a period of 490 years.
2. From exodus of Israel till the building of Solomon’s Temple (BC 1606 to 1005) was 601 years. The period of the judges when Israel was rebellious and strayed away from God was 111 years. If this period of time is deleted from 601, we arrive at a duration of 490 (601-111) years again.
3. From the dedication of Solomon’s Temple till the order issued by Artaxerxes to restore the damaged Temple (BC 1005 to 445) was 560 years. If we remove 70 years of Babylonian captivity from 560, we get the period of 490 years again.
4. ‘Seventy weeks’ in the vision of Daniel point to the time from the order of Artaxerxes till the appearance of Messiah (Dan. 9:25). This duration can be divided into three periods:
 - i) Seven weeks: This duration of 49 (7×7) years represents the time for the restoration of Jerusalem. The prophecy, “The streets shall be built again, and the wall”, was fulfilled at the time of Nehemiah. 49 years are to be counted from

BC 445, the year in which Artaxerxes issued the order for restoration of Jerusalem.

- ii) Sixty two weeks: This period of 434 (62x7) years follows the previous period of 49 years. At the end of this period Messiah will be 'cut off'.
- iii) One week: The age of Gentiles begins at the 'cutting off' of Messiah. It is not known when exactly the age of the Gentiles will end. When that age is completed, Messiah will take away His church. The following seven years will see the restoration of Israel (Rom. 9:11:25-26).

As we have already seen, the first 69 weeks (483 years) begin with the issue of the order by Artaxerxes in BC 445. Daniel's vision predicts the 'cutting off' of the Messiah after 483 years counting from BC 445 (Dan. 9:26). According to the Gregorian calendar that we follow, Artaxerxes issued his order on March 14, 445 BC (first day of Nisan in the 20th year of his reign – Neh. 2:1). 'Hosannah Sunday' – the day on which Messiah entered Jerusalem riding upon an ass as predicted by Prophet Zachariah (Zach. 9:9; Luke 19:36-38) was on April 4, 31 AD. The period between the two events is 476 years and 21 days. Biblical prophecies are calculated on the basis of lunar calendar years of 360 days. Therefore, 476 years in the Gregorian calendar works out as 483 years in the lunar calendar. Messiah was crucified at the precise time as God revealed to Daniel through Gabriel. We can be sure that the prophecies relating to the seventieth week will also be fulfilled in future at the right time.

The Age of Grace:

When Jesus Christ entered Jerusalem riding upon an ass as the "king of the daughter of Zion", it was the fulfillment of prophecy. But He was rejected by the Jews. Thus ended the prophetic sixtynine weeks in the history of the Jews. Messiah was crucified as atonement for the sins of mankind. After His resurrection and ascension to heaven, He anointed His disciples with the Holy Spirit on the Day of Pentecost. Thus began the building of His Church. People from all nations and languages and creeds joined His

Church by accepting Him as their Lord and Saviour and receiving salvation by grace. The process is continuing even today. Therefore, this age is called the Age of Grace or the Age of the Church or the period of Gentiles. But for Israel, it is a period of rejection and can be counted as a period kept in between two brackets. The Age of Grace will come to a close with the rapture of the Church from the world and the seventieth week will begin for Israel. We shall study the events of the seventieth week in the next lesson.

Prophecies concerning the seventy weeks are being fulfilled very accurately. We are happily living in the Age of Grace between the sixtynineth week and the seventieth week. Let us praise God for His glorious plan for mankind and receive salvation by grace, be baptized, live a spirit filled life and wait for the rapture of the Church at the second coming of our Lord.

Questions:

1. When did Daniel receive the revelation about the “seventy weeks”?
2. Explain the meaning of “seventy weeks”.
3. How many periods of “seventy weeks” were there in the history of Israel? When was the first period?
4. When were the second and third periods of “seventy weeks”?
5. When did the fourth period of “seventy weeks” begin? Show how this period is divided into smaller sections.
6. Explain how the prophecy about the Messiah being “cut off” after seven and sixtytwo weeks was fulfilled?
7. What are the names given to the period between the sixtynineth week and the seventieth week? What are special characteristics of this Age?
8. Which is the important event that should happen just before the seventieth week?

LESSON 11

Seventieth week Appearance of “the man of iniquity” and related events

Objective: To learn that the “mystery of iniquity” is already working in the world and wait in holiness and purity of life for the righteous kingdom of Messiah.

Memory verses:

2 Thes. 2:9-10

The coming of the lawless one by the activity of Satan will be with all power and with pretended signs and wonders, and with all wicked deception of those who are to perish, because they refused to love the truth and so be saved.

Lesson:

Dan. 9:23-27;
2 Thes. 2:1-12;
2 Tim. 3:1-5

Introduction

How true it is to say that iniquities and apostasy are increasing in the world day by day! Violence, injustice and immorality are certainly gaining ground. Note what has been mentioned in 2 Tim. 3:1-5 and 2 Thes. 2:7 about the widespread prevalence of unrighteousness in the last days. While a small group of believers keep their life holy and wait for the coming of the Lord, a large group is waiting for the appearance of the “man of iniquity” who is Anti-christ. Let us learn some events related to the appearance of the Anti-christ.

I. The period before the seventieth week and Israel's

condition: The condition of Israel between the sixtyninth week and seventieth week is revealed in Dan. 9:26: *“And after threescore and two weeks shall Messiah be cut off, but not for himself: and the people of the prince that shall come shall destroy the city and the sanctuary; and the end thereof shall be with a flood, and unto the end of the war desolations are determined”*. Messiah (Jesus Christ) was cut off (crucified). During the time of the same

generation, Jerusalem city and the holy Temple were destroyed by the army of Titus Caesar in AD 70. Even Jesus had foretold the same events in Luke 21:6, 20-24, but the Jews did not pay any attention. Eusubius, the historian has recorded that Christians who remembered the words of Jesus ran away and escaped from Jerusalem when they saw the army of Titus surrounding the city. In that attack, one million Jews were killed and 95,000 were taken prisoners. The desolation of Jerusalem was completed in AD 135 when remaining Jews rebelled against the Roman emperor and were totally displaced from their home land. They were scattered into different nations of the world. The words of Deut. 28:62-67 were literally fulfilled in their history. They were able to re-establish their own nation in Palestine after the world wars of the 20th century. But wars have been going on there continuously. According to Daniel's prophecy, wars are foretold till the end.

II. Important events connected with the seventieth week:

1. Apostasy: Apostasy (falling away from faith) is foretold as the first sign of the seventieth week. *"Let no man deceive you by any means: for that day shall not come, except there come a falling away first, and that man of sin be revealed, the son of perdition"* (2 Thes. 2:3). The 'falling away' mentioned here is not about individuals. The reference is to a general condition of the nominal Christian world which does not fully accept the plan of salvation offered through Christ and lives in their own way according to their own reasoning and logic. As we see nowadays, efforts of religious leaders are aimed at establishing a universal brotherhood of all religions and a universal system of social justice. Word of God is not considered as totally inspired by God or literally acceptable. The world gives recognition to Christian leaders who preach such views and deny fundamental principles of the Bible. They are praised as large hearted and open minded. We can very well recognize this situation as the one predicted by Paul that would happen before the appearance of the 'man of sin'. Therefore we can conclude that the Church will be taken away very soon and the 'man of sin' will begin his rule on earth.

2. Appearance of Anti-christ: Word of God clearly indicates that after the rapture of the Church, the iniquity now pervading the earth will materialize in the form of a person: *“And he shall confirm the covenant with many for one week: and in the midst of the week he shall cause the sacrifice and the oblation to cease, and for the overspreading of abominations he shall make it desolate, even until the consummation, and that determined shall be poured upon the desolate”* (Dan. 9:27). When he begins his rule, he will enter into a covenant with the Jews and Christian groups and will be in a conciliatory mood with them. But soon he will change his attitude and begin persecution. In the middle of the week, that is after three and a half years, sacrifices and worship will be stopped and his image will be installed in the Temple. Jews will be compelled to worship the image (Dan. 9:27; 11:31, 37-39). They will be subjected to great persecution when they refuse to worship the image. Many will be martyred (Rev. 6:9; Matt. 24:21-22). (We will learn about the Anti-christ in detail in the next lesson).
3. Six events mentioned in Dan. 9:24: *“Seventy weeks are determined upon thy people and upon thy holy city, to finish the transgression, and to make an end of sins, and to make reconciliation for iniquity, and to bring in everlasting righteousness, and to seal up the vision and prophecy, and to anoint the most Holy”*.
 - i. “Finishing the transgression”: Jews will end their transgression at the beginning of the seventieth week. They will repent as a nation and look to Christ whom they pierced (Isa. 59:20; Zech. 12:10; Rom. 11:26-27).
 - ii. “Making an end of sins”: The reference is to the casting of Satan, who is the cause of all sin, into the bottomless pit for thousand years (Rev. 20:1-3). This happens at the end of the seventieth week.
 - iii. “Making reconciliation for iniquity”: Israel as a nation will repent and turn towards Christ (Zech. 12:10-14). A fountain will remain open for the remission of their sins (Zech. 13:1).

They will be cleansed (Zech. 14:21). Thus their sin of rejecting Christ will be pardoned.

- iv. "Bringing in everlasting righteousness": Messiah will establish His righteous kingdom on earth at the end of the seventieth week. *"A King shall reign in righteousness and princes shall rule in judgement"* (Isa. 32:1, 15-18). *"We, according to his promise, look for new heavens and a new earth, wherein dwelleth righteousness"* (2 Pet. 3:13)
- v. "Sealing up the vision and prophecy": Vision and prophecy are not needed after the seventieth week (1 Cor. 13:9-10). Hence they are sealed.
- vi. "Anointing the most Holy": Reference here is to the anointing of Messiah as King and Priest and the consecration of the Temple which will be built during the Millennial rule (Zech. 6:12-13). The Temple is described in chapters 41- 48 of Ezekiel.

Conclusion

In which prophetic period are we living today? The seventieth week known as the Great Tribulation is soon approaching. The moral condition of the world declares that the 'man of sin' or the Anti-christ will soon appear. What is your hope in the midst of all this? Let us wait for the coming of our Lord in holiness.

Questions

- 1) This world is at present divided into two groups awaiting the appearances of two persons. For whom are both the groups waiting?
- 2) When did the sixtyninth week end? With what event does the seventieth week begin?
- 3) What are the names given to the period between the sixtyninth week and the seventieth week? What are the events of this period relating to Israel?
- 4) Explain the verse: *"there come a falling away first"* written by Apostle Paul.
- 5) Write down the verse, Dan. 9:27 and explain its meaning.
- 6) Write down the verse, Dan. 9:24 and describe the six events mentioned in it.

LESSON 12

“Man of Iniquity’ or Antichrist

Objective: To learn the scriptural truths about Antichrist and prepare for the second coming of our Lord.

Lesson:

Dan. 11;
2 Thes. 2:1-12;
Rev. 13:1, 17:7-14

Memory verses:

1 John 2:18, 22

Children, it is the last hour; and as you have heard that antichrist is coming, so now many antichrists have come; therefore we know that it is the last hour.

Who is the liar but he who denies that Jesus is the Christ? This is the antichrist, he who denies the Father and the Son.

Introduction

A great number of people in the world are deceived by Satan and they rebel against Christ and His teachings. Apostasy and iniquity are pervading all over the world. At the same time we see that a small minority of people in all parts of the world are being saved and turning into spiritual awakening. What does this development signify? The whole world is dividing itself into two groups. One group is paving the way for the Antichrist while the other group is waiting for the appearance of Lord Jesus Christ and the establishment of the kingdom of God. In which group are you?

Who is Antichrist?

Antichrist is a world leader who will emerge onto the scene in the last days displaying satanic glory and power together with signs and wonders and claiming the stature and position of the

creator of the universe and the Saviour of mankind, Jesus Christ. He will deny the existence of God the Father and Jesus Christ (1 John 2:22). Notice the various names given to him in the Bible:

1. Man of sin (2 Thes. 2:3-8)
2. Man doomed to destruction (2 Thes. 2:3 - NIV)
3. Antichrist (1 John 2:18,22)
4. Beast (Rev. 13:1-2; 17:7-8; 19:20)
5. Little horn (Dan. 7:8; 8:9-12)
6. Wicked king and master of intrigue (Dan. 8:23 – NIV)
7. Coming prince (Dan. 9:26)
8. King who does as he pleases (Dan. 11:36)
9. King of Babylon (Isa. 14:4-12)

The picture of Antichrist in the book of Daniel

1. In chapter 7:

The future of world empires was revealed to Nebuchadnezzar through the four different sections of the image in his dream. After 48 years God revealed to Daniel the nature and future of all nations through the vision of four beasts which came out of the sea. Daniel saw a little horn growing among the ten horns of the fourth beast. At that time three of the old horns were uprooted. The little horn had eyes like the eyes of a man and a mouth that spoke boastfully (Dan. 7:8). The meaning of this vision was also revealed to Daniel by God. The ten horns are ten kings who will come from the fourth kingdom. After them another king will arise, different from the earlier ones; he will subdue three kings. He will speak against the Most High and oppress his saints and try to change the set times and the laws. The saints will be handed over to him for a time, times and half a time ($1 + 2 + \frac{1}{2} = 3 \frac{1}{2}$ years). But the court will sit, and his power will be taken away and completely destroyed forever. Then the sovereignty, power and greatness of the kingdoms under the whole heaven will be handed over to the saints, the people of the Most High. (Dan. 7:24-28). Antichrist is the world leader who comes out of the ten nations. His persecution will increase in the

latter half of the seventieth week. His rule will end with the appearance of the Messiah and power and dominion will rest with the saints of God.

2. The small horn in chapter 8:

Daniel was pondering over his vision in ch. 7. Therefore God gave him another vision two years later when he was in the palace of Shushan. A ram with two horns representing Medo-Persian empire was destroyed by a goat (representing Greek empire) which came from the west without touching ground. Its great horn (Alexander) was broken and in its place four new beautiful horns appeared. A little horn came out of one of the four horns and grew in power to the south and to the east and toward the Beautiful Land (Dan. 8:5-9). Daniel was told that the four horns were the four kingdoms arising out of the Greek empire and a cruel and cunning leader would arise out of one of the kingdoms. This leader would fight against the Lord of lords and would be destroyed.

The little horns in both the chapters 7 & 8 point to the same person, that is, Antichrist. When we study both the visions together, we can understand that Antichrist will be emerging from one of the nations belonging to the Greek empire which later became parts of the Roman empire.

3. The vision of chapter 11:

More details about the appearance of Antichrist were revealed to Daniel. Up to verse 35 of ch. 11, details are given of the wars and treaties between Syria, the northern kingdom and Egypt, the southern kingdom during BC 323 to 146. Prophecies mentioned in these verses were literally fulfilled in history. The mighty king in v. 3 is Alexander whose Greek empire was divided into four and taken over not by his offsprings, but by his military commanders. The southern kingdom of Egypt became strong under its governor, Ptolemylegus, who became king. Syria was then under the control of Egypt and governed by Selucius. Selucius declared independence and became stronger than Egypt. The two nations were constantly at war with each other.

There were also short periods of peace through treaties and marriages. The black deeds of the Syrian king, Antiochus Euphphanus, are forecast in verses 21 to 36. Jewish historians record that he attacked Jerusalem, desecrated the Temple and sacrificed a pig on the altar. His army installed the idol of Jupiter in the Temple and killed many Jewish worshippers. He is a shadow figure of Antichrist of the future. A group called Jacobees resisted Antiochus and declared independence in Judea for a few years. These events were forecast in this chapter.

Antichrist:

Read carefully verses 36 to 44. It may appear that the king who does as he pleases and who exalts and magnifies himself above every god and will say unheard of things against the God of gods is a reference to the Syrian king, Antiochus Euphphanus or any of his successors. Read v. 40: "At the time of the end the king of the South (Egypt) will engage him in battle, and the king of the North (Syria) will storm out against him with chariots and cavalry and a great fleet of ships. He will invade many countries and sweep through them like a flood". Thus it is clear that the reference is not to any Syrian king but to someone different. The reference is to an autocratic ruler who will rise up against Israel and persecute them. The beast described in Rev. 13:1-10; 17:7-14 with ten horns and seven heads is also Antichrist. The beast's boasting, cruelty and command to people to worship him or his image are characteristics of the king mentioned in Dan. 11:36. "He is antichrist, that denieth the Father and the Son" (1 John 2:22). "The man of lawlessness and the man doomed to destruction" mentioned in 2 Thes. 2:3-8 is also the same person. The beast representing Antichrist that Apostle John saw in Revelations had characteristics similar in one way or the other to all the four beasts that Daniel saw in his vision. Hence it can be concluded that the rule of Antichrist will have all the despotic natures of the kingdoms of Babylon, Medo-Persia, Greece and ancient Rome.

Christ and Antichrist: Comparisons of the two persons are listed below:

Antichrist	Christ
1. Came from above John 6:38	Comes from the deep Rev. 11:7
2. Came in the name of Father John 5:43	Comes in his own name John 5:43
3. Humbles Himself Phil. 2:8	Exalts himself 2 Thes. 2:4
4. Despised by the world Isa. 53:3	Honoured by all Rev. 13:3,4
5. Exalted in the end Phil. 2:9	Cast into the bottomless pit Rev. 19:20
6. Saviour Luke 19:10	Destroyer Dan. 8:24
7. Good Shepherd John 10:4	Worthless shepherd Zech. 11:15-17
8. Son of God Luke 1:35	Man doomed to destruction 2 Thes. 2:3
9. Mystery of the fear of God 1 Tim. 3:16	Mystery of iniquity 2 Thes. 2:7; 1 Tim. 3:16
10. The truth John 14:6	The lawless one 2 Thes. 2:8

The end of Antichrist: We shall learn about the end of Antichrist in the next lesson. Let us not be conformed to this world which is getting ready for the appearance of the Antichrist, but be prepared for the second coming of Messiah putting our total trust in Jesus Christ and the Word of God.

Questions

1. World is grouping into two divisions. Which are the two groups?
2. Who is Antichrist? List other names given to him.
3. How is Antichrist pictured in 7th and 8th chapters of Daniel?
4. Prove that the little horn growing in the midst of ten horns of the beast and the small horn growing from one of the four horns of the goat, both represent Antichrist.

5. What is the summary of the prophecies in Dan. 11:1-35?
6. Which person is the subject of the prophecies from v. 36 onwards of Dan. 11?
7. What are the characteristics of Antichrist mentioned in Dan. 11? How are they similar to the prophecies elsewhere about him?
8. Compare the characteristics of Christ and Antichrist.

LESSON 13

Concluding events

Objective: To learn that people of God live a life of glorious hope and do wonderful things for the Lord while the nations of the world grope in darkness without any certainty about their future.

Lesson:

Dan. 11:40 – 12:13

Memory verses: Dan. 12:2-3

And many of those who sleep in the dust of the earth shall awake, some to everlasting life, and some to shame and everlasting contempt. And those who are wise shall shine like the brightness of firmament; and those who turn many to righteousness, like the stars for ever and ever.

Introduction

What is the future of this world? How are things going to end? We live at a time when these questions are agitating people's minds. Word of God gives clear answers to these questions. Bible reveals how this earth and the whole mankind defiled by sin can be redeemed from that miserable condition through Jesus Christ. Prophet Daniel learnt that the righteous will be rewarded and unrighteousness will come to an end. He died with great hope in the Lord. In today's adverse circumstances, we must stand steadfast in our hope and do mighty works for our Lord because we have the revelation of end times through the Word of God.

1. The end of Antichrist

i) Covenants:

We have already learnt that Antichrist will establish his autocratic rule for one week or 7 years in the world after the rapture of the church. He will have false prophet as his most important aide (Rev. 19:20). He will enter into covenants with many at the beginning of his rule (Dan. 9:27). His first covenant will be with the ten nations that join him (Rev. 17:12-13). As the head of the ten-nations' federation, he will enter into a covenant with Israel. Israel will be under the mistaken impression that Antichrist is the promised Messiah. Moreover, the nominal Christians who remain on earth after the rapture of the Church will unite under one leader and also enter into a covenant with Antichrist. The harlot described in Rev. 17:1-18 is this union. Its headquarters will be Rome, the great city which is established on ten hills and has power over kings of the earth.

ii) Breaking of covenant:

After three and a half years of the reign of Antichrist, Satan will be thrown on to the earth by Michael, the archangel. Satan will make his dwelling inside Antichrist and give him all his power and authority (Rev. 12:7-12, 13:2-5). Then Antichrist (the beast) will break his covenant with Israel and start persecution. He will enter Jerusalem with his army and establish his throne there and say 'unheard of' things against God (Dan. 11:36). Israel will realize their mistake and resist Antichrist. As a result and as Jesus foretold, "there will be great distress, unequaled from the beginning of the world until now — and never to be equaled again" (Matt. 24:15-21-NIV). For a time they will fall by the sword or be burned or captured or plundered (Dan. 11:33). It is shown in Revelation that many Jews will flee to the desert and will be protected there (Rev. 12:14). Thus Israel will have to pass through great tribulation. It is revealed in the Bible that Israel will repent of their sin at this time and believe in Jesus Christ (Rev. 12:13-17, 12:5). Two witnesses who are "the two olive trees and the two lampstands that stand before the Lord" will minister to Israel during this period (Rev. 11:3-12).

Antichrist will break his covenant with the union of nominal Christians (harlot). "The beast and the ten horns you saw will hate the prostitute. They will bring her to ruin and leave her naked; they will eat her flesh and burn her with fire" (Rev. 7:15-16-NIV). He will also break his covenant with other nations of the world.

iii) Battle of Armageddon:

When Antichrist will be marching triumphantly to Egypt, "reports from the east and the north will alarm him" (Dan. 11:44). Jesus Christ, the King of kings and the Lord of lords, will descend to earth in all His glory with His saints and heavenly host to establish His kingdom (Jude 15;

2 Thes. 1:6). "Then the Lord will go out and fight against those nations, as he fights in the day of battle. On that day his feet will stand on the Mount of Olives, east of Jerusalem" (Zech. 14:3-4). "Then the Lord my God will come, and all the holy ones with him" (Zech. 14:5). It is this news that will alarm Antichrist. "He will set out in a great rage to destroy and annihilate many. He will pitch his royal tents between the seas at the beautiful holy mountain" (Dan. 11:44,45). His army will engage in a war with the heavenly host in the valley of Meggiddo. "Out of his mouth comes a sharp sword with which to strike down the nations" (Rev. 19:15). "And then the lawless one will be revealed, whom the Lord Jesus will overthrow with the breath of his mouth and destroy by the splendor of his coming" (2 Thes. 2:8). "This is the plague with which the Lord will strike all the nations that fought against Jerusalem: Their flesh will rot while they are still standing on their feet, their eyes will rot in their sockets, and their tongues will rot in their mouths" (Zech. 14:12-13). Read Ezek. 38:21-23, 39:1-20; Rev. 19:11-21: The destruction coming upon Antichrist and his army is described in these passages. Antichrist and his chief aide false prophet will be captured alive and thrown in the lake of fire (Rev. 19:20). No one will be able to save them. The battle of Armageddon will thus come to an end. Satan will be chained and thrown into the bottomless pit. Then the Millennium rule will begin.

2. Services of Michael, the great prince:

Daniel 12 begins with a reference to Michael, the great prince who protects the nation of Israel. At the rapture of the Church, the

sound of the archangel is heard and the principalities and powers of darkness which prevent the resurrection of saints are thrown out from heavenly places (1 Thes. 4:16). Such a role for Michael is implied as we read about Michael arguing with the devil for the body of Moses in Jude (v.9). Michael has a part to play in protecting Israel during the great tribulation and in defeating Antichrist and his army in the battle of Armageddon. "Are not all angels ministering spirits sent to serve those who will inherit salvation?" (Heb. 1:14).

3. Resurrection of the dead:

It can be clearly understood from the book of Daniel that the resurrection of the dead is a certainty. Read Dan. 12:2-3, 12:13. Although it is mentioned in one sentence that those "who sleep in the dust of the earth will awake: some to everlasting life, others to shame and everlasting contempt", other references in the Bible explain that both groups do not resurrect at the same time. At the first phase of the second coming of our Lord, those who die in Christ will resurrect and those who are alive will be transformed and together they will meet the lord in the clouds (1 Thes. 4:16-17). The saints who become martyrs during the great tribulation will also resurrect before the 'Millennial rule' (Rev. 20:4-6). These resurrections together are called 'the first resurrection'. Blessed are those who are part of the first resurrection and they will rule with Christ for a thousand years. There will be a resurrection of the unsaved people after the 'Millennial rule' which is described in Rev. 20:12-15. Each person will be judged according to what he has done and thrown into eternal fire.

4. The Book is sealed:

Daniel is ordered by God to seal his book of prophecy (Dan. 12:4). On the other hand, God asks John not to seal the book of Revelation. The prophecies in Daniel's book have been understood only in the last age (church age) with the help of the Holy Spirit. The book of Revelation confirms the importance of the book of Daniel. Let us praise God for revealing His plans through the study of the book of Daniel.

5. The conversation between angels:

We read the conversation of angels about the great tribulation in Dan. 12:5-11. We hear them saying: "It will be for a time, times

and half a time. When the power of the holy people has been finally broken, all these things will be completed". Israel will be persecuted for three and a half years or 1260 days.

6. The two numbers - 1290, 1335:

Two different numbers are mentioned in Dan. 12:11,12. "From the time that the daily sacrifice is abolished and the abomination that causes desolation is set up, there will be 1,290 days. Blessed is the one who waits for and reaches the end of the 1,335 days". The actual period of the great tribulation from the time that the abomination is set up in the Temple is 3 ½ years or 1260 days. Probably there will be a delay of 75 days (30+45) before the establishment of the 'Millennial Kingdom'. There are no clear references to explain this delay. But it may be assumed that 75 days are utilized to clear all the traces of evil and destruction caused by the rule of Antichrist before establishing an environment of peace and righteousness.

7. Rest and inheritance of the saints:

God speaks great words of comfort and hope to Daniel in the end (Dan. 12:13). Death is rest for the saints of God. "Blessed are the dead who die in the Lord from now on — they will rest from their labor, for their deeds will follow them" (Rev. 14:13). After their rest, they will resurrect with heavenly bodies. It will happen at the first phase of the second coming of our Lord. The saints will rise up with transformed bodies to meet their Lord in mid air and then enter into the bridal chamber. Rewards will be presented there according their deeds in a gathering of all saints and heavenly hosts. "Incorruptible crown" (1 Cor. 9:25), "Crown of rejoicing" (1 Thes. 2:19), "Crown of righteousness" (2 Tim. 4:8), "Crown of glory" (2 Peter 5:4; Rev. 4:4), "Crown of life" (James 1:12) and other rewards are kept for the saints of God. Let us resolve to live and work for our Lord so that we can receive our rewards and crowns together with Daniel and all the other saints of God beginning with Abel.

Questions:

1. With whom does Antichrist enter into covenants in the beginning of his rule? When does he break those covenants?
 2. Quoting Bible references, describe the events that take place after Antichrist breaks the covenants.
 3. Which is the battle marking the end of Antichrist? What are the events associated with this battle?
 4. Describe the roles of Michael at different times.
 5. Write notes on the following in one paragraph:
 - i. The numbers 1290 & 1335 mentioned in Dan. 12:11-12.
 - ii. Rest and rewards of the saints of God.
 6. 'People who know God will stand steadfast and do mighty works for the Lord'. Give reasons. Do you have such an experience?
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LESSON 14

Book of Revelation - Introduction

Objective: To learn about the greatness of the Book of Revelation, the only prophetic book in the New Testament and get a glimpse of the glory of Jesus Christ as revealed in the Book.

Lesson:

Revelation Chapter 1

Memory verses: Rev. 1:6-7

....and made us a kingdom, priests to his God and Father, to him be glory and dominion for ever and ever. Amen. Behold, he is coming with the clouds, and every eye will see him everyone who pierced him; and all tribes of the earth will wail on account of him. Even so. Amen.

Introduction:

What is the future of this world? This is a question that is agitating the minds of philosophers and political leaders these days. The advanced nations of the world have stockpiled and are still producing enough weapons to destroy the world in a short

time. At such a time the revelations that God has given about future events give hope and comfort to His people. The last book of the Bible reveals the everlasting kingdom of Jesus Christ and the events of the end times. Hence it is very important to read and study this book.

Author of the book:

Read Rev. 1:1-2; 22:16: What do these passages tell us? From the introduction, the revelation of Jesus Christ, we learn that the author is Jesus Christ, Himself. The statement, "I, Jesus, have sent my angel to give you this testimony for the churches" confirms the same truth. God, the Father, gave the revelation to Jesus Christ and He revealed the same to His beloved disciple, John, through His angel. John recorded what he saw in a book.

Time and circumstances in which the book was written:

Christians were severely persecuted by the Roman emperor, Domitian, in AD 95-96. All the apostles except John had already become martyrs for the Lord by that time. John was serving the Lord in Ephesus and was also persecuted. Finally the Roman rulers banished him to Patmos, a rocky island in the Egean sea, situated about 30 miles away from the coast of Asia Minor. As he was on the island of Patmos because of the word of God and the testimony of Jesus, on the Lord's Day he was in the Spirit. He was given the revelation at that time and he recorded the same as he was told (Rev. 1:9-11).

Specialities of the book:

1. This book is the only prophetic book in the New Testament.
2. As it foretells events of the future, it has similarities with the prophetic book of Daniel which is the 27th book of the Old Testament.
3. This book is mostly written in symbolic language. There are more than 300 symbols in the book. All the symbols have clear and amazing meanings which can be understood by a person who has scriptural knowledge.

4. This is the only book of the Bible which promises blessings to both who read and who hear the words from it.
5. This is a book of fulfillment. Genesis, the first book of the Bible records what human beings and the earth lost because of man's sin. The book of Revelation describes how everything is restored and redeemed through Jesus Christ. For example, in place of the earth cursed in Genesis, a new heaven and a new earth appear in Revelation. Adam and Eve were banished from the Garden of Eden where the tree of life grew. But we see man returning to the tree of life in Revelation (Rev. 21:1; 22:1,2).
6. The book is filled with various events. In the fourth chapter, we see the picture of the living creatures and elders worshipping the One seated on the throne day and night. The fifth chapter onwards, events which happen on breaking of the seals are described. Finally, the Antichrist, the false prophet, Satan and his army and all those whose names are not found in the Book of Life are thrown into the lake of fire (Rev. 19:20; 20:9,10,15). Then new earth, new heaven and the holy city of New Jerusalem are established (Rev. 21:1-5).
7. The book displays Jesus Christ in various ways:
 - a) We see Jesus Christ as the eternal judge and King of kings adorned with all glory and honour. John sees One like the Son of Man dressed in blazing glory in ch. 1 (vs. 1-20). In several passages like Rev. 5:8,11,12; 7:10-12:4:2-11; 11:15-17; 19:21; 20:11-15; 22:3-5, the Risen Christ is described in great splendour as our High Priest, prophet and eternal King.
 - b) Christ is depicted as the Lamb who was slain from the foundation of the world. The book refers to Jesus as the Lamb 26 times. Lamb's shedding of blood, redemption of mankind through the shed blood, the worship of the Lamb, the victory of the Lamb, His glory, His royal reign, His marriage and His throne are vividly portrayed in the book. (See Rev. 5:6-14; 6:1-7; 7:10-17; 13:8; 14:1; 17:14; 19:4-9; 21:22-23; 22:1-7).

Contents of the book:

The contents of the book can be divided into 3 sections. Read Rev. 1:19.

1. What you have seen: Description of Jesus Christ who appeared in the midst of seven golden lampstands (Rev. 1:10-20).
2. What is now: Messages to seven churches (Rev. 2:1-3:22). Messages with regards to the Church Age.
3. What will take place later: Rev. chs 4-22: Events that are yet to happen after the close of the Church Age.

The book of sevens:

Book of Revelation is sometimes referred to as 'book of sevens'. Bible which begins with seven days associated with the creation account ends with the book of sevens. Let us look at the seven sevens:

1. Seven churches and messages to them (Rev. 2:1-3:22)
2. Seven seals (Rev. 6:1-8:5)
3. Seven trumpets (Rev. 8:7-11:19)
4. Seven symbolic visuals (Rev. 12:1-13:18)
5. Seven bowls of wrath (Rev. 15:1-16:21)
6. Seven judgements (Rev. 17:1-20:15)
7. Seven new things (Rev. 22:1-5)

There are many other sevens also in the book: Seven lamp stands (1:12), seven stars (1:16), seven spirits (1:4), seven horns and eyes of the Lamb (5:6), seven thunders (10:3-4), seven heads and seven crowns of the dragon (12:3), seven heads of the scarlet beast (17:3), seven hills (17:9), seven kings (17:10). But the sequence of events are connected with the seven sevens listed above.

We have seen, so far, a brief introduction to the book of Revelation. How amazing is the book and the person of Jesus Christ described in it! To Him who loves us and has freed us from our sins by His blood, and has made us to be a kingdom and priests to serve His God and Father — to Him be glory and power for ever and ever! Amen.

Questions:

1. Who is the author of the book of Revelation? What is the role of Apostle John in the writing of the book?
2. Describe the time and circumstances in which the book was written.
3. What are the specialities of the book?
4. Prove that the book is the revelation of Jesus Christ.
5. State the 3 sections into which the contents of the book can be divided?
6. Why is the book known as the 'book of sevens'?

LESSON 15

Messages to churches from the Master

Objective: To be blessed by beholding Lord Jesus Christ and by hearing His voice.

Lesson:

Rev. chs 1,2,3

Memory verses: Rev. 3:2-3

Awake, and strengthen what remains and is on the point of death, for I have not found your works perfect in the sight of my God. Remember then what you received and heard; keep that, and repent. If you will not awake, I will come like a thief, and you will not know at what hour I will come upon you.

Introduction:

Do you know a few names of people mentioned in the Bible who received a revelation of God and heard His voice? Prophets Isaiah and Ezekiel and Apostle Paul had visions from God and heard His voice and their ministries became very powerful after such experiences. Read Isa. 6:1-8; Eze. 1:1-3:4; Acts 9:3-5. We must also receive visions of the Lord and hear His voice so that we may be used mightily in our ministries. The first four chapters of Revelation record how John received the vision of the Master of the churches and what the Lord had to say to the churches.

Seven fold glory of the Lord:

Look at the words describing Jesus Christ in Rev. 1:4-8,17,18. Christ is variously described as the faithful witness, the firstborn from the dead, the ruler of the kings of the earth, One who loves us and has freed us from our sins by His blood, and has made us to be a kingdom and priests to serve His God and Father, One who is coming with the clouds, the Alpha and the Omega, who is, and who was, and who is to come and the Almighty. Each of the above expressions is very meaningful and deserves study in detail. The beauty and glory of the Lord as seen by John are described in vs. 12 to 16.

- i) Head and hair (1:14): His head and hair, white like wool, as white as snow, point to His ancientness (eternal existence) and His holiness.
- ii) Eyes (1:14): His eyes like blazing fire point to the fact that no creation is hidden from His sight. Everything is open and naked before His eyes (Heb. 4:12; Psa. 139:1-8).
- iii) Feet (1:15): His feet like bronze glowing in a furnace declare that He will judge Satan and the world and trample them under His feet (Rev. 19:15).
- iv) Voice (1:15): His voice like the sound of rushing waters declares His royalty and power.
- v) Hand (1:16): In His right hand, he holds seven stars which represent the ministers of the church. They enjoy security in His right hand (John 10:28-29).
- vi) Mouth (1:16): The sharp double-edged sword coming out of His mouth represents words of judgement that will proceed out of His mouth (Rev. 19:15).
- vii) Face (1:16): His face was like the sun shining in all its brilliance. The face of Jesus shone like this on the Mount of Transfiguration (Matt. 17:2). He will appear as the Sun of Righteousness at His second coming (Mal. 4:2). All effects of darkness will disappear from the world.

John saw the Lord dressed in a robe reaching down to His feet with a golden sash around His chest and walking amidst seven golden lamp stands. The Lord is walking in the midst of the lamp stands which are His churches. He examines whether the lamps have oil in them and the wicks are cleaned up. If we approach Him earnestly, He will fill us with His Spirit and clean our wicks so that we can shine forth in the world. (Compare the vision of John with the vision of Daniel in Dan. 10).

Messages to the seven churches:

Messages from the glorious Lord to seven churches are recorded in chs 2 and 3. They are addressed to seven churches which existed in the western part of Asia Minor in the first century. Although there were many more churches in the region, these seven churches represent them all. More than that, they also point to the conditions and experiences of all believers at all times. If we study the messages in conjunction with church history, we can identify them with various periods in the church age. The seven churches represent seven periods from the first century till the second coming of Jesus Christ. Below are the periods associated with the seven churches:

1. Ephesus: Loose church: AD 70-120 (Rev. 2:1-7)
2. Smyrna: Persecuted church: AD 120-312 (Rev. 2:8-11)
3. Pergamum: Lustful church: AD 312-600 (Rev. 2:12-17)
4. Thyatira: Ritualistic church: AD 606-1520 (Rev. 2:18-29)
5. Sardis: Reformed church: AD 1520-1750 (Rev. 3:1-6)
6. Philadelphia: Loving church (with brotherly love): AD 1750-1914 (Rev. 3:7-13)
7. Laodicea: Lukewarm church: AD 1914 onwards (Rev. 3: 14-22)

Every message begins with an introduction by the Master about His special attributes. Then appreciation, drawbacks, exhortation and promises to the church follow. No drawbacks are mentioned

in the messages to Smyrna and Philadelphia churches. What does the Master see when He looks at us with His eyes like flaming fire? There are no words of appreciation to Sardis and Laodicea churches. How sad it is! Let us examine ourselves in the light of the messages to churches. Let us sanctify ourselves by finding our mistakes and rectifying them. Let us be ready for the Lord's coming. Awake and rejuvenate ourselves.

Questions:

1. Which are the names used in Rev. 1 to describe the greatness of Jesus Christ?
2. Describe the seven fold glory of Christ as seen by John. What spiritual truth is indicated by each member of Christ's body?
3. Name the churches to which the Master gives messages in Revelation. Describe the condition of each church in one word.
4. What do the seven lamp stands and the seven stars signify?

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LESSON 16

He who has an ear, let him hear – I

(Ephesus, Smyrna, Pergamum and Thyatira)

Objective: To repent and be restored by heeding to the messages given by Jesus Christ to the churches in Asia Minor.

Lesson:

Rev. chapter 2

Memory verses:

Rev. 2:4-5

But I have this against you, that you have abandoned the love you had at first. Remember then from what you have fallen, repent and do the works you did at first. If not, I will come to you and remove your lampstand from its place, unless you repent.

Introduction:

The Spirit of God convicts us of our mistakes in various ways. It is our duty to heed to His voice and correct ourselves at such times. The messages to seven churches speak to us, too, who are living at this time.

1. Ephesus: The meaning of the word 'Ephesus' is 'loose'. The Lord, who walks in the midst of His church carrying the 'angels' of the church in His right hand, knows us and our works very well. He praises the good works of the church, their rejection of false apostles and their hatred of Nicolaitans who introduce priestly rituals (2:2,3,6). But He blames the church on one point (v.4). He mentions the mistake of forsaking their first love as a serious sin. The exhortation and warning to the church is given in v.5. They are advised to repent and do the things that they did first. Otherwise their lamp stand will be removed from its place. The promise of the right to eat from the tree of life in the paradise of God is given in v.7. Historically Ephesus depicts the condition of the church during the period AD 70-120. 'Nicolaitans' are 'those who subjugate people'. Authoritarian priesthood had already started to enter the church. But believers stood against the trend which is commended by the Lord. But their first love, meaning love for God and for fellow brethren had diminished. The Spirit of God strongly urges restoration in that matter. How is our condition now? We are standing firmly for the truths of our faith. But do we sincerely love God and our fellow believers? We may possess many good attributes, but if we have no love, all other things are in vain. Let us not forsake love while being engaged in debates on matters of faith.

2. Smyrna: The word 'smyrna' means 'bitterness'. The Lord who is "the First and the Last, who died and came to life again" knows the bitter conditions (sufferings and poverty) of the church. He supports them and urges to remain faithful till the end. Crown of life is promised to those who are victors. Smyrna church represents the period of tribulation from AD 120 to 312. "Persecution for ten days" may be referring to the ten murderous attacks on the church from the Roman emperors, Nero to

Diocletus. Or, it could be about the ten persecutions at the end of Diocletus' rule. God allowed these persecutions to restore the church from its forsaking of the first love. Let us face persecutions boldly and endeavour to receive our crowns of life at the end.

3. Pergamum: The word 'pergamum' means 'bound by love' or 'married'. Church who is a bride betrothed to be married to her bridegroom, Jesus Christ, has strayed from her love for Him (2 Cor. 11:2-3). Pergamum had reached a high level of prosperity and idolatry among all cities of Asia Minor. It had sunk to such a low spiritual level that it could be called the throne of Satan. Believers had to face many temptations in such a situation. Historically, Pergamum represents the period of time from AD 312 to 606. Persecutions ended in AD 312. Roman emperor, Constantine, turned favorable to Christians calling himself as a follower of Christian religion and brought the church and the state together. He tried to strengthen his kingdom by bringing together the Christian church and the local heathen religion. Thus the doctrines of Baalam and Nicolaitans entered the church teachings. Baalam's advise to Israel led them to idolatry and immorality (Num. 25:1,2,3,9). Constantine converted heathen temples to churches and their idols into images of Christian saints. Priests of the church were given royal positions and comforts. Repentance and rebirth were not required to become members of the church. The rituals that are presently seen in main line churches are practices of Roman and Greek religions. (Eg. Festivals, procession of images, idol worship, etc.) Doctrines of Nicolaitans or Priesthood entered the church at this time. The differences between laity and clergy were formalized in the council of Nice in AD 325. The church leaders in Rome, Antioch and Alexandria were accorded royal throne status. The rituals which entered the church in fourth century are still being followed now in traditional churches. The Lord warns that if they do not repent, they will be cut down by the sword of condemnation. Look at what happened to the church in Russia!

4. Thyatira: The Lord condemns the forsaking of faith and the rituals of sacrifice prevalent in Thyatira. Although the church

does a lot of good works, it allows immorality and idol worship. Jezebel, wife of Ahab, compelled Israel to worship idols instead of true worship of God during the days of Elijah. In a similar fashion, the period from AD 606 to 1520 saw the church declining into such ways of idol worship and immorality. During that period which is described as a dark age of the church, idol worship, sacrifice called 'Qurbana' and similar rituals became very prominent. Word of God (Bible) was banished from the church. Just as Jezebel killed the prophets of God, leaders like John Wycliffe, William Tyndale and Martin Luther who raised their voice of reformation against these evils were severely persecuted. It is estimated that 347,704 people were killed in Europe for standing for reformation.

We will study the remaining three messages in the next lesson. It is seen from history that persecutions can lead to reformation in the church. Material prosperity very often leads to spiritual decline. Believers and the church as a whole must remain steadfast in their love for God, holiness and separateness in all circumstances.

Questions:

1. What are the good qualities of the church of Ephesus? What is mentioned as the one drawback in them? Which period in history does this church represent?
2. Which qualities have been commended in the church of Smyrna? Which period does this church represent?
3. What are the bad qualities mentioned about the church of Pergamum? Which period does this church represent?
4. Describe the comparison between the church of Thyatira and Queen Jezebel. Describe the condition of the church during the period of time that this church represents.

LESSON 17

He who has an ear, let him hear – II

(Sardis, Philadelphia, Laodicea)

Objective: To repent and be restored by heeding to the messages given by the Master, Jesus Christ, to the churches in Asia Minor.

Lesson:

Rev. chapter 3

Memory verses:

Rev. 3:20-22

Behold, I stand at the door and knock; if anyone hears my voice and open the door, I will come in to him and eat with him, and he with me. He who conquers, I will grant him to sit with me on my throne, as I myself conquered and sat down with my Father on his throne. He who has ear, let him hear what the spirits says to the churches.

Introduction:

Consider how the unscriptural rituals and idol worship that we see even today in traditional churches had their beginning? Let us now continue with the churches of Sardis, Philadelphia and Laodicea.

5. Sardis: The word 'sardis' means 'reformation or renewal'. The church of Sardis represents the reformation which started in the beginning of the 16th century. The great reformer, Martin Luther, prepared a list of 95 items (Theses) regarding blind beliefs and misrule prevalent in the Roman Catholic church and nailed it on October 31, 1517 on the door of the Wittenberg church in Germany. He called people to come out of the church from under the authority of the Pope. Along with this movement, Bible was translated into local languages of Europe. 'Justification by faith' was declared

among people. But this reformation had only a partial benefit to the church and did not result in a full spiritual cleansing of the believers. That is why the words of the Lord are significant in the context: "I know your deeds; you have a reputation of being alive, but you are dead. Wake up! Strengthen what remains and is about to die, for I have not found your deeds complete in the sight of my God". Reformation was effective mainly in administrative and doctrinal matters. It did not have much influence on issues of personal sanctification or evangelism. But a few believers were spiritually revived and the Lord commends them as having "not soiled their clothes and who will walk with Him, dressed in white". Even in these days, there could be people arguing for reformation but not having any spiritual life. What is your experience? AD 1520-1750 is considered as the period of the Sardis church.

6. Philadelphia: The word 'Philadelphia' means 'brotherly love'. The church is described as a good example of being obedient to Word of God and engaged in spreading the gospel. The Lord is giving many precious promises to the church. Historically speaking, Philadelphia church represents all full gospel believing believers and groups from AD 1750 till today. This period is characterized by spiritual revivals and spread of the gospel, setting aside debates and disputes associated with the reformation. Revival speakers like John Wesley, D.L. Moody and C.H. Spurgeon and missionaries like William Carey, David Livingston, Adoniram Judson, John Paynton and Hudson Taylor rose up for the work of the Lord during this time. Great revivals spread through Britain, USA, Canada, Sweden and Germany. Missionaries from these countries traveled to South America, Africa, India, Burma, China and Pacific Islands to preach the gospel and did sacrificial service to translate Bible into many local languages and made the Word of God available to local people. There has been no other time in history when doors are open for the spread of the gospel as this time. The Lord's statement: "I have placed before you an open door that no one can shut" is very much valid these days. The Lord adds: "I know that you have little strength, yet you have kept my word and have not denied my name". The statement is very much applicable to full gospel churches of this time. But His

promises are very reassuring: “Since you have kept my command to endure patiently, I will also keep you from the hour of trial that is going to come upon the whole world to test those who live on the earth”. What are the promises in verses 9 to 13?

1. Nominal Christians will come to know the truths of the gospel.
2. They will be protected at the time of the Great Tribulation which will come upon the whole world.
3. They will be made pillars in the Temple of God.
4. They will be given new names.

Let us remain steadfast in the same condition as that of the Philadelphia church and be partakers of the promises of the Lord.

7. Laodicea (Lukewarm church): Laodicea was a very prosperous place in Asia Minor. We learn about the existence of a church there from Col.4:10. Apostle Paul wrote a letter to them. There is no word of commendation of this church from the Lord. What are their drawbacks?

1. Lukewarm
2. Self satisfied
3. Wretched, pitiful, poor, blind and naked.

The church is poor and wretched internally, although she appears rich and blessed from outside. Christ has been thrown out of the church. Towards the end of Philadelphia church period, Laodicean church situation has begun and is getting stronger. Full gospel churches and believers are losing their spiritual fervour. Christians have many things to boast about. Riches, influential positions, schools, colleges, hospitals, charity homes and huge church buildings are in plenty without spiritual life. There is no experience of real love or joy or peace or forgiveness. Moral standard has deteriorated. Even believers try to be part of the world culture. Strong winds are blowing in favour of modernism and ecuminism. Inspiration of the Word of God, virgin birth of Jesus Christ, redemption through the death and resurrection of Jesus Christ, resurrection of the dead, second coming of Jesus Christ,

heaven, hell and such fundamental truths of our faith are not accepted by many Christian leaders. The exhortation to the church is to let Jesus inside the church. Every member should accept Jesus in his heart as his saviour and Lord and every church should give Jesus a preeminent position within itself. One who overcomes will dine with Jesus Christ and will get the right to sit with Him on His throne. What is your decision? Will you submit yourself for a committed life with Jesus?

The Church Age is coming to a close. Let us examine ourselves in the light of the messages to churches. Let us revive ourselves by recognizing our faults and repenting. Let us claim all the blessings that are promised to the churches. He who has an ear, let him hear.

Questions:

1. What is the meaning of the word 'Sardis'? What is the testimony that the Lord gives about the church in Sardis?
2. Quote relevant historical events and indicate the period of time represented by Sardis.
3. What is the meaning of the word 'Philadelphia'? What are the points of commendations that the Lord gives about the church in Philadelphia?
4. Which period in church history does Philadelphia church represent? Describe the greatness of this period.
5. Which are the faults that are mentioned by the Lord about the church in Laodicea? Describe how each one of them is prevalent now in the present day church.
6. Write down the names of the seven churches of Asia Minor mentioned in Revelation, indicate the literal meaning of each name and mention the period of time in church history that each of them represents.

LESSON 18

The Lamb and the Sealed Book

Objective: To learn about the glorious qualities of our Lord Jesus Christ who proceeds quickly after the 'Church Age' to complete the redemption of mankind and the earth and prepare ourselves for His coming.

Lesson:

Rev. chapter 4,5 & 6

Memory verses:

Rev. 5:9

*...and they sang a new song, saying,
"Worthy art thou to take the scroll
and to open its seals,
for thou wast slain and by thy blood
didst ransom men for God.
from every tribe and tongue and
people and nation,*

Introduction:

The evils and turmoils that we witness today are indications that this age is soon coming to a close. The wise men of the world are not able to predict what is going to happen in the future. Hence they are all puzzled. But there is no reason for believers who study and understand the Word of God to be apprehensive about anything. What we are witnessing are events that should take place in fulfillment of the prophecies associated with completion of the redemption of the world. The events recorded in Rev. 4 onwards are visions that God gave to John and which should take place in future. The initial scene is in heaven. Throne of Judgement, sealed book, Lamb who is able to open the seals and the events which happen as the Lamb opens each seal are described in Rev. 4, 5 & 6. We shall learn these topics briefly.

Open heaven:

A door is opened in heaven. John hears a voice: "Come up here". John sees a glorious throne set up in heaven and God sitting on it. This vision of John is clearly pointing to the 'rapture' of the church mentioned in 1 Cor. 15:52-54 and 1 Thes. 4:14-17. The church will enter into the heavenly chamber along with the Lord.

Throne:

Look at the glory of the throne and the Person sitting on the throne in heaven described in Rev. 4:2-11. Compare with the vision of Prophet Ezekiel in Ezek. 1:26-28. Glorious God is surrounded by bright light and a glorious rainbow. The rainbow declares that God enforces His law and keeps His promises. After the Great Flood, God made a covenant with Noah and mankind: "I have set my rainbow in the clouds, and it will be the sign of the covenant between me and the earth. — Whenever the rainbow appears in the clouds, I will see it and remember the everlasting covenant between God and all living creatures of every kind on the earth" (Gen. 9:11-17).

Flashes of lightning, rumblings and peals of thunder came from the throne. Hence it can be concluded that this is not the Throne of Grace, but Throne of Judgement. The 24 elders sitting around the throne on 24 other thrones are representatives of the Old Testament saints and the New Testament saints redeemed by the blood of the Lamb. Their white robes point to their priestly standing and their crowns and thrones point to their kingdoms. Redeemed saints of God are priests and kings (1 Pet. 2:9; Rev. 1:6). The seven lamps described as seven spirits of God blazing in front of the throne point to Holy Spirit. Holy Spirit has entered heaven along with the church. What looked like a sea of glass, clear as crystal in front of the throne points to perfect peace and pure joy in heaven. Around the throne are seen four living creatures. They execute orders from the One seated on the throne and guard the throne. Such living creatures who bring honour to God on the throne are seen in the visions of Ezekiel (Ezek. 1:5-14) and Isaiah (Isa. 6:2-3) also. The living creatures give honour, thanks and glory to God continually. The

elders cast down their crowns before God and worship Him. Let us bow down before our God who is worthy of worship by all.

Sealed Book:

After Judgement Throne is set up and rewards are distributed to saints, the Lamb takes up the book (scroll) from the hands of God. Rev. 5 records these events. The sealed scroll is the document containing the privileges lost by Adam because of sin and their restoration to man. There is a law given to Israel that if a poor man sells his inherited property, it should be redeemed by the nearest kinsman (Lev. 25:25). Examples of such deals are found in Ruth 4:1-12 and Jer. 32:6-12. Such documents used to be recorded in scrolls made of animal skins. When the inheritance is to be redeemed, the seals of the scroll are broken and the deal is completed. Likewise our Lord Jesus Christ became our kinsman (being born as a man) and redeemed mankind by His blood. Events happen while the seals of the scroll are broken in order to complete the restoration of man's privileges. Hence the question is asked, who is capable of breaking the seals of the scroll? At that time, Jesus Christ, the Lion of Judah and the Root of David appears as a slain Lamb before the throne of God and takes the scroll from God. Then four living creatures and 24 elders give glory to the Lamb and fall and worship Him. Hosts of angels also sing songs of victory and give honour and glory to the Lamb. Let us think how much we ought to be grateful to the Lamb of God who redeemed us by His blood and restored all our lost inheritance. The slain Lamb of God is worthy to receive all honour and power and glory and riches and praises.

The Lamb (Christ) opens the seals:

The process of restoration of property to the rightful owner after redeeming it from an unauthorized custodian starts as the Lamb breaks the seals of the book. Satan is the unauthorized custodian and Jesus Christ is the rightful owner. Satan begins to resist the real owner when He enters His inheritance. The fight begins as Christ breaks the first seal. The world is moving towards this series of events.

First seal:

One of the four living creatures shouts in a voice like thunder, "Come". Enemies are being called one by one. A man appears on a white horse with a bow. He receives a crown and proceeds swiftly as a victor. He is Antichrist who appears as a man of peace and deceives everybody including Israel and becomes the ruler of the world.

Read Dan. 11:21: "He will invade the kingdom when its people feel secure, and he will seize it through intrigue" Israel will mistakenly accept him as Messiah and their saviour. But his true colours will come out as the second seal is broken.

Second seal:

A fiery red horse appears at the opening of the second seal. The rider has a sword in his hand and he takes away peace from the earth. Men kill each other and the earth becomes a place of wars, blood shed and revolution. Events foretold in Matt. 24:60 happen. Antichrist establishes his reign on earth through bloodshed. (Similar events happening nowadays are forerunners of the future).

Third seal:

At the opening of the third seal, a black horse appears whose rider holds a pair of scales. The scene foretells the famine that will grip the earth following the bloodshed. Read Matt. 24:7: "There will be famines and earthquakes in various places".

Fourth seal:

The yellow horse that appears at the opening of the fourth seal points to death. It foretells the innumerable deaths that will result from wars, famines, diseases and wild animal attacks. Refer to the prophecies in Ezek. 14:21; Isa. 5:13-16.

Fifth seal:

John sees "under the altar the souls of those who had been slain because of the word of God and the testimony they had

maintained". These are the martyrs from Israel who are killed during the rule of Antichrist. As prophesied in Dan. 9:27 ("In the middle of the 'seven' he will put an end to sacrifice and offering"), in the middle of the seven year rule, Antichrist will deny freedom of worship to Israel and begin great persecution. Many will be killed as the gospel of the kingdom (Millennium) is preached. This is a fulfillment of the prophecy in Matt. 24:9-14.

Sixth seal:

With the breaking of the sixth seal, earthquakes, unusual solar and lunar eclipses and showers of meteors will happen as signs of the wrath of God. The heavenly bodies will be shaken. But even then, man does not repent and turn to God.

An interval follows after the natural disasters described above. Then the seventh seal is broken and seven trumpets appear on the scene. Great wrath is poured upon the earth at the blowing of each trumpet. We shall study these events which happen till the Millennium in the following lessons.

Present day events of the world proclaim the imminent rapture of the Church. Antichrist will rule the earth after the rapture. We learnt in this lesson the terrible incidents that will happen during the time. Those left behind from rapture will pass through the great tribulation. Let that not happen to any one of us. Let us commit ourselves in the presence of our Lord to live a holy and acceptable life.

Questions:

1. Describe the Throne and the One seated on it as John saw in his vision.
2. What does the rainbow around the Throne signify?
3. What is the significance of the 'sealed book'?
4. Describe the Lamb who is worthy to break the seals of the book. Why is He referred to as the 'Lion of Judah' and the 'Root of David'?
5. Describe the events which follow at the breaking of each of the first six seals.

LESSON 19

Seventh seal and seven trumpets

Objective: To understand the greatness of God's plan of redemption of mankind and the terrible punishment man will face if he neglects so great a salvation.

Lesson:

Rev. chapters
7,8,9,10,11

Memory verses:

Rev. 7:9-10

After this I looked, and behold, a great multitude which no man could number, from every nation, from all tribes and peoples and tongues, standing before the throne and before the Lamb, clothed in white robes, with palm branches in their hands, and crying out with loud voice, "Salvation belongs to our God who sits upon the throne, and to the Lamb!"

Introduction:

God's plan for man is to make him eligible for heavenly blessings after redeeming him from the clutches of Satan. Satan and Antichrist who oppose this plan will be defeated. Let us learn the order of events that happen before the opening of the seventh seal and immediately after that.

Interval:

Two events happen pointing to the grace of God in the midst of Great Tribulation:

1. Angels of God seal and separate 144,000 people who do not bow down before the 'talking image' of Antichrist. These people are from the 12 tribes of Israel, 12,000 from each tribe. It

may be noted that 2 tribes, Dan and Ephraim, who led the people into idolatry in olden days (1 Kings 12:25-30) are not listed in this crowd.

2. Another group of people who experience God's redeeming grace is seen in the seventh chapter. (Rev. 7:9-17). John sees a great multitude from every nation, tribe, people and language, standing before the throne in front of the Lamb, wearing white robes and holding palm branches in their hands. These people are washed by the blood of the Lamb, but they are not part of the Church because the Church has already been taken up to heaven. This multitude of people are those who were cleansed by the blood of the Lamb after hearing the gospel of the kingdom during the Great Tribulation. They escape from martyrdom and enter the heavenly temple and worship the Lord day and night. God Himself shall wipe away tears from their eyes.

Seventh seal:

As the seventh seal is broken, there is silence in heaven for half an hour. The silence is the forerunner of dreadful events that are to follow. Then John sees seven angels standing in the presence of God who are given seven trumpets. Another angel, who had a golden censer, came and stood at the altar. He was given much incense to offer, with the prayers of all the saints, on the golden altar before the throne. Then the angel took the censer, filled it with fire from the altar, and hurled it on the earth; and there came peals of thunder, rumblings, flashes of lightning and an earthquake. The wrath of God is being poured upon the earth in answer to prayers of the Jews who are left on the earth. Then the seven trumpets are blown one by one. At the blowing of the first six trumpets, plagues come upon the earth similar to the ones that happened to Egyptians at the time of Moses.

First trumpet:

There came hail and fire mixed with blood, and a third of the earth was burned up (Rev. 8:7). See also: Exo. 9:23-24.

Second trumpet:

Something like a huge mountain, all ablaze, was thrown into the sea. A third of the sea turned into blood (Rev. 6:8,9). See also: Exo. 7:19-20.

Third trumpet:

A great star, blazing like a torch, fell from the sky on a third of the rivers and on the springs of water and a third of the waters turned bitter and many people died from the waters that had become bitter (Rev. 8:10-11). See also: Jer. 9:13-15.

Fourth trumpet:

A third of the sun was struck, a third of the moon, and a third of the stars, so that a third of them turned dark. A third of the day was without light, and also a third of the night (Rev. 8:12). See also: Exo. 10:21-22, Luke 21:25, Joel 2:31.

Fifth trumpet:

Out of the smoke from the Abyss, locusts came down upon the earth with power that of scorpions of the earth to torture those people who did not have the seal of God on their foreheads for five months (Rev. 9:1-12). See also Exo. 10:14.

Sixth trumpet:

Four angels who were bound at the great river Euphrates were released to kill a third of mankind. These evil angels had two hundred million mounted troops whose breastplates were fiery red, dark blue, and yellow as sulfur. The heads of the horses resembled the heads of lions, their tails were like snakes and out of their mouths came fire, smoke and sulfur.

It may be noted that in spite of these plagues, men did not repent and did not stop worshiping demons, and idols of gold, silver, bronze, stone and wood, nor did they repent of their murders, their magic arts, their sexual immorality or their thefts.

Interval before the seventh trumpet (Rev. chs. 10,11):

A final warning is given to man before the blowing of the seventh trumpet. Mainly two events take place during this interval:

1. A mighty angel comes down from heaven, robed in a cloud, with a rainbow above his head. His face is like the sun and his legs are like fiery pillars. He plants his right foot on the sea and his left foot on the land and declares, "There will be no more delay". This angel represents Christ. He is holding an open scroll. John takes the scroll and eats it as directed. It tasted sweet as honey in his mouth, but his stomach turned sour. Hence it can be concluded that John was given a book containing bitter events of the future.

2. John is commanded to measure the Temple of Jerusalem excluding the outer court because it has been given to the gentiles. John is told that the gentiles will trample on the holy city for 42 months and during this period, two witnesses will prophesy clothed in sackcloth. In the second half of the Great Tribulation, Antichrist will install his talking image in the Jerusalem Temple and persecute those who do not bow before the image. The two witnesses who appear among the Jews to minister to them are, most probably, Moses and Elijah, judging from their modes of activity. They will be killed by Antichrist and their dead bodies will lie on the streets of Jerusalem for three and a half days and be seen by the whole world. After three and a half days they will resurrect and go to heaven. An earthquake will follow and many will die.

Seventh trumpet:

After the interval, the seventh trumpet is sounded. Events which follow are described in the book up to ch. 20:3. There were loud voices in heaven, saying: "The kingdom of the world has become the kingdom of our Lord and of his Christ, and he will reign for ever and ever" (Rev. 11:15). The twenty-four elders, who were seated on their thrones before God, fell on their faces and worshiped God. Then John sees God's temple in heaven opened, and the ark of covenant inside it. As these events are taking place in heaven, the world below enters the third stage of tribulation. Flashes of lightning, rumblings, peals of thunder, an earthquake

and a great hailstorm follow. We shall learn later incidents in the following lessons.

Consider the great tribulations that those who reject the gift of salvation offered to mankind through the sacrifice of Jesus Christ on the cross. Therefore let us be ready to be taken up in the clouds in the first phase of Christ's coming.

Questions:

1. Describe the two events that display the grace of God even in the days of the Great Tribulation.
2. Explain the identity of the 144,000 people who are sealed and separated by the angels.
3. Describe the main events that happen when the seven trumpets are blown.
4. What are the incidents that happen during the interval between blowing of the sixth and seventh trumpets?
5. What are the loud voices heard in heaven at the blowing of the seventh trumpet?

LESSON 20

Seven signs

Objective: To be clear in the understanding of the future of the world as revealed in the scriptures.

Lesson:

Rev. chapters 12,13

Memory verses: Rev. 12:10

I heard a loud voice in heaven, saying, "Now the salvation and the power and the kingdom of our God and the authority of his Christ have come, for the accuser of our brethren has been thrown down, who accuses them day and night before our God.

Introduction:

Satan and his powers are trying their best to defeat God's plan of salvation for man. Satan is employing all his strength to fight against God and His people as he is nearing his final judgement. In the middle of the Great Tribulation, seven signs appear as described in Rev. chs. 12&13. We shall now study about these manifestations.

1. Woman clothed with the sun:

A woman clothed with the sun appears in heaven with the moon under her feet and a crown of twelve stars on her head. She cries out in pain as she is about to give birth. A red dragon stands in front of the woman to devour her child. She gives birth to a son, a male child, who will rule all the nations with an iron scepter. The child is immediately snatched up to God's throne. The woman flees into the desert to a place prepared for her by God, where she is taken care of for 1,260 days (Rev. 12:1-8, 13-16). The woman represents Israel who flee to the wilderness to escape from Antichrist. (Read Gen. 37:9).

2. Male child (Rev. 12:23):

The male child born to the woman is Jesus Christ who was born into the world as a child of Israel. He will rule all the nations with an iron scepter. (Read Psa. 2:8-9, Isa. 9:6, Rom. 9:5). He is the One who was taken to the throne of God (Eph. 1:20-23).

3. An enormous red dragon (Rev. 12:3-17):

The enormous red dragon with seven heads, ten horns and seven crowns on the heads is Satan, the old serpent. He tried to kill the child but did not succeed. He spewed water like a river, to overtake the woman who was fleeing to the wilderness. But the earth helped the woman by opening its mouth and swallowing the river. Enraged at this, the dragon stood on the shore of the sea, ready to terrorize the Jews during the Great Tribulation.

4. The arch angel (Michael):

Satan and his hosts are defeated and cast out from heavenly places by Michael. The work of Michael is mentioned in passages like Dan. 12:1, 10:13 & Jude 9. The arch angel mentioned in 1 Thes. 4:16 is also Michael.

5. The remnant of Jews (Rev. 12:17):

After the attempt at destroying the woman (Israel) and her male child (Jesus Christ) fails, Satan is trying to destroy those left in her family. The reference is to the remnant of Jews who are passing through the Great Tribulation. This group consists of those who obey God's commandments and who have the testimony of Jesus.

6. Beast that comes out of the sea (Rev. 13:1-10):

The sea represents a group of gentile nations. The beast coming out of the sea resembles a leopard, but has feet like those of a bear and a mouth like that of a lion. Beast in John's vision is a mixture of the three of four beasts that appeared to Daniel in Dan. 7. Prophecies associated with Antichrist are given in Dan. 7:8, 7:24-25, 8:9-12 and 8:22-25. The scarlet beast of Rev. 17:3 with seven heads and ten horns represents the same person. We learnt in Lesson 12 about the emergence of a world leader from among a ten-nation union of the Roman Empire that will come into existence in the last days. This leader is given great power and authority by the dragon (Satan). One of the heads of the beast is fatally injured but is healed miraculously. People of the world are amazed at this miracle and bow before the dragon and the beast. The beast will utter blasphemy and continue his dreaded rule for 42 months. Read 2 Thes. 2:3-10.

7. Beast that comes out of the earth (Rev. 13:11-18):

This beast emerges as a helper of the first beast (Antichrist), deceiving the inhabitants of the earth by performing great and miraculous signs. He is also called the 'False Prophet'. The two beasts are separately mentioned in Rev. 16:13, 19:20 & 20:10. A kind of trinity of Satan can be seen here: dragon, beast and false prophet. When the first beast (Antichrist) is ruling the whole world, the second beast (False Prophet) shows miraculous signs and compels people to make images of the beast and worship him. The whole world comes under one religion. Ecumenism is spreading in the world trying to bring every one under one banner. This trend will end up in the worship of Antichrist. People who do

not worship the image of the beast will undergo terrible persecution. The false prophet is symbolized by the harlot woman sitting on a scarlet beast with seven heads and ten horns in Rev. 17.

World events leading to the rapture of the Church and the appearance of Antichrist and False Prophet are evident even now. The Holy Spirit will be taken away after the rapture of the church. Then Antichrist and False Prophet will make their appearance. At the end of the seventieth week, the Beast and False Prophet will be thrown alive into the lake of fire. If we fight against the deceptions of Satan and live a life of holiness and separation, we will be taken up at the first phase of our Lord's coming. Do you have this assurance?

Questions:

1. Why do we say that the woman wearing the sun is Israel?
2. Who is the male child born to the woman wearing the sun?
3. Who is the red coloured dragon? Why is he standing on the sea shore?
4. Who is the chief angel that throws out Satan from heaven?
5. Who is the beast coming out of the sea? List the prophecies concerning him in the Old Testament.
6. What is the other name of the beast coming out of the earth?
7. Why do we say that there is a kind of trinity in Satan? Who are the members of that trinity?

LESSON 21

Seven bowls of wrath

Objective: To learn that the works of God are great and wondrous and His ways are righteous and true, and to fear and honour His name.

Lesson:

Rev. chapters
14, 15 & 16

Memory verses:

Rev. 15:3-4

And they sing the song of Moses, the servant of God, and the song of the Lamb, saying, "Great and wonderful are thy deeds, O Lord God the Almighty!

Just and true are thy ways, O king of the ages! Who shall not fear and glorify thy name, O Lord? For thou alone art holy.

All nations shall come and worship thee, for thy judgements have been revealed."

Introduction:

People of God undergo sufferings in the world. We see many evil doers prospering in life. Do you feel sad thinking that this is unjust? But when we study the history of the world and the Word of God prayerfully, we will come to the conclusion that God's ways are just and true. The plan of God for the world is perfect. The events recorded in Rev. 14, 15 & 16 declare that God generously rewards those who are faithful to Him and dreadful everlasting condemnation awaits those who join Satan's camp for short term pleasures. God shows that He is just by issuing warnings before executing His punishments on the evil men and by protecting His saints during perilous times.

1. The scene on Mount Zion (Rev. 14:1-5):

John sees the Lamb, standing on Mount Zion, and with Him 144,000 who had His name and His Father's name written on their foreheads. Mount Zion mentioned here is not the literal

Jerusalem, but heavenly Jerusalem, the city of the living God (Heb. 12:22-23). Who are these 144,000 people? They held harps given to them by God and sang the song of Moses the servant of God and the song of the Lamb and stood before the throne and before the four living creatures and the elders. As they are singing in front of the elders, they are obviously not a group from the Old Testament or New Testament saints represented by the elders. They are the ones who are victorious against the beast during the Great Tribulation and who have kept themselves undefiled from idolatry or fornication. We saw 144,000 people in ch. 7 drawn out of the tribes of Israel. They are the first fruits from the nation of Israel and not from the Church.

2. Proclamations by three angels:

1. An angel is seen flying in midair, proclaiming the eternal gospel: "Fear God and give him glory, because the hour of his judgment has come. Worship him who made the heavens, the earth, the sea and the springs of water" (Rev. 14:6-7).
2. A second angel proclaims about the fall of Babylon the Great. He warns that Babylon, the center of evil and apostasy will soon come to an end (Rev. 14:8).
3. A third angel warns that those who worship the beast and his image and receive his mark will drink of the wine of God's fury. He calls for patient endurance on the part of the saints who obey God's commandments and remain faithful to Jesus. Following this a voice from heaven is heard: "Blessed are the dead who die in the Lord from now on. They will rest from their labor, for their deeds will follow them". Although this truth is applicable to all saints, here it is particularly referring to the martyrs who die in the persecution of the Antichrist. People who receive the mark of the beast will be condemned to eternal suffering. But those people who remain steadfast in their faith in God will be taken to have eternal rest with Christ Jesus. How wonderful will be that eternity!

3. Harvest of the earth and clusters of grapes (Rev. 14:14-20):

There appears a white cloud and seated on the cloud is one "like a son of man" with a crown of gold on his head and a sharp

sickle in his hand. An angel comes out of the temple and declares that the harvest of the earth is ripe. So he who is seated on the cloud swings his sickle over the earth and the earth is harvested. The harvest points to the righteous judgement of the world by Jesus Christ. The judgement includes all the punishments up to the battle of Armageddon. Another angel is seen coming out of the temple in heaven with a sharp sickle. He swings his sickle on the earth, gathers clusters of its grapes and throws them into the great winepress of God's wrath. Blood flows out of the press, rising as high as the horses' bridles for a distance of 1,600 stadia. This bloodbath points to the battle of Armageddon described in ch. 19 (See Isa. 63:3-6).

4. Seven bowls of wrath (Rev. 16:1-21):

John sees a temple, that is, the tabernacle of the Testimony, open in heaven and seven angels coming out of the temple. The angels are given seven golden bowls filled with the wrath of God. And the temple is filled with smoke from the glory of God. The angels pour out the bowls of wrath on the earth one by one.

1. When the first angel pours out his bowl on the land, painful sores break out on the people who have the mark of the beast and worship his image.
2. The second angel pours out his bowl on the sea and it turns into blood. Every living thing in the sea dies.
3. The third angel pours out his bowl on the rivers and springs of water and they become blood.
4. The fourth angel pours out his bowl on the sun and the sun is given power to scorch people with fire.
5. The fifth angel pours out his bowl on the throne of the beast and his kingdom is plunged into darkness. Men curse the God of heaven because of their pains and their sores, but they refuse to repent.
6. The sixth angel pours out his bowl on river Euphrates and its water is dried up. Three evil spirits that looked like frogs come out of the mouths of the dragon, beast and false prophet. They

go out to the kings of the whole world performing miraculous signs and gather them for the battle on the great day of God Almighty. They come together at a place called Armageddon.

7. When the seventh angel pours out his bowl into the air, a loud voice from the throne in the temple is heard, saying, "It is done!" Then there comes flashes of lightning, rumblings, peals of thunder and a severe earthquake. The great city splits into three parts. The cup filled with the wine of the fury of God's wrath. Is given to Babylon the Great. Islands and mountains disappear. Huge hailstones fall from the sky. Men curse God on account of the plague of hail.

Effects of the pouring out of the seventh bowl of wrath end with "seven conclusions" that are described in Rev. 17 to 20 and the appearance of Jesus Christ on Mount Olives. We shall learn about them in the following lessons.

God judges sin and rewards those who suffer for His name's sake. Glory be to His name.

Questions:

1. Who are the 144,000 people standing with the Lamb on Mount Zion? What is Mount Zion referring to?
2. Describe the three proclamations in Rev. 14.
3. About whom is the verse: "Blessed are the dead who die in the Lord from now on" (Rev. 14:13) talking about? Explain the fact that the verse is also applicable to saints of all times.
4. Explain the 'harvest of the earth' and 'gathering of the clusters of grapes' described in Rev. 14.
5. Describe the places where the seven bowls of wrath are poured and the results.
6. The pouring out of the wrath of God establishes the truth that God is just and righteous in His actions. Explain.

LESSON 22

Seven judgements

Destruction of Babylon the Great and wedding of the Lamb

Objective: To learn that the evil systems of this world will come to an end and the Lord will establish His righteous kingdom and hence to live a holy life separated from the evils of this world.

Lesson:

Rev. chapters
17,18 & 19

Memory verses: Rev. 18:4

*Then I heard another voice from heaven saying,
“Come out from her, my people,
lest you take part in her sins,
lest you share in her plagues;*

Introduction:

Modern world and its systems are decaying. As we read in the scriptures, people have become lovers of themselves, lovers of money, boastful, proud, abusive, disobedient to their parents, having a form of godliness but denying its power (2 Tim. 3:1-5). Hence today's religious, commercial and political systems and their originators have to be brought to justice. The judgements and resulting happenings are described in Rev. 17 to 20. Ways to escape these judgements and the blessed experiences of the people of God are also given in these passages. Judgements of God are pronounced on Babylon the harlot, city of Babylon, Antichrist, false prophet, followers of Antichrist, Gog & Magog, Satan and evil men. Judgements of the first four groups are pronounced during the period of the Great Tribulation - between the rapture and the glorious appearance of Christ. We shall study in this lesson, the first two judgements and also the wedding of the Lamb that takes place later.

1. The harlot Babylon or the church of Babylon:

When Israel worshipped other gods and idols, she was called the harlot in the Old Testament (Ezek. 16:25,35,36). Similarly

Babylon the Great who is being called a harlot woman represents a church that has fallen away from the love for Jesus Christ, the Bridegroom. Even the Apostles have prophesied the emergence of such a condition of the Church after their time (2 Cor. 11:2-3, Acts 20:29-30, 1 Tim. 4:1-3, 2 Pet. 2:1-3). So it is not difficult to conclude the identity of “Babylon the Great, the mother of prostitutes and of the abominations of the earth” mentioned in Rev. 17. Let us consider some of her attributes:

1. Remember the Church history that you learned in Class 8: Which was the organization that had unwanted relationship with kings of the world from the time of Emperor Constantine and made people drunk with the wine of false teachings and idolatry?
2. **She is sitting on many waters:** Waters are peoples, nations, multitudes and languages (Rev. 17:1,15). The church in the city of Rome expanded to many nations and languages with government help after the conversion of Emperor Constantine and became a great multitude. Even other nominal Christian churches are flowing into a union with the Roman Catholic church which already has a membership of more than 710 million. Negotiations are being conducted for unity between the Pope, Archbishop of Canterbury, Catholicos of Malankara Orthodox church and Bishops of other churches. The woman whom John sees as ‘sitting on many waters’ can be none other than this unified Christian church.
3. **She is traveling on a scarlet beast (Rev. 17:3):** This beast is similar to the fourth beast that Daniel saw. It has seven heads and ten horns and comes out of the sea. It represents Antichrist who becomes the head of the newly emerging Roman empire. During the first half of the Great Tribulation, Antichrist will enter into a covenant relationship with Babylon church. The seven heads of the beast are seven hills on which the woman sits (Rev. 17:9). It is well known that the city of Rome is situated on seven hills. The headquarters of the Babylon church will be Rome.

4. **She is dressed in purple and scarlet** and wearing gold, precious stones and pearls (Rev. 17:4): Official robes of Bishops, Cardinals and other dignitaries of the Roman church are scarlet color. Crowns, crosses, etc., that they wear are adorned with gold and precious stones. Their luxurious palaces are beyond description!
5. **She is drunk with the blood of those who bore testimony to Jesus (Rev. 17:6):** In the first three centuries the Roman empire drank the blood of Christian martyrs. Later on, the Roman church became powerful enough to kill thousands of saints labeling them as Protestants who disagreed with their doctrines and practices. In coming days, the Roman church will have greater powers through Antichrist to persecute those who bear testimony of Jesus.

End of harlot (the nominal church): The harlot will rule the world using her covenanted relationship with the Antichrist during the first half of the Great Tribulation.:At the end of 3 1/2 years, Antichrist will be possessed by Satan and bring the harlot to ruin and leave her naked and burn her with fire (Rev. 17:16). It means that Antichrist will break his covenant with the church and will nationalize their churches, schools, hospitals, etc. and destroy all their leaders. Then all the rulers of the union will hand over absolute power to him. At this time, the Church, the Bride of Christ, will be in heaven receiving her rewards. Let us keep our separation and holiness and be ready for the coming of our Lord.

2. City of Babylon (Commercial Babylon):

Rev. 18 describes the end of the commercial Babylon after the end of Babylon church. Right from the time of the Roman emperors till the last days, the city of Rome has been the source of all evils, blind rituals and beliefs and hence deserves just punishment. Also the fall of Babylon represents all that are ungodly and materialistic in the world. They all come to an end after the removal of the christless church. The merchandise of Babylon are listed in Rev. 18:4-20: The extent of moral degradation can be seen from the fact that even bodies and souls of men have become goods for sale. The city will be destroyed by earthquake and fire.

Notes:

1. Rome has been taken as synonymous with Babylon because historically ancient Babylonian religion shifted from there to Pergamum and then to Rome.
2. Some scholars are of the opinion that Babylon refers to the ancient Babylon itself. Then a new city of Babylon has to be rebuilt for the fulfillment of this prophecy.

Marriage of the Lamb and celebrations in heaven (Rev. 19:1-10):

After the destruction of Babylon church and Babylon city, roar of great multitudes are heard four times shouting 'Hallelujah'. 'Hallelujah' has been translated: 'Praise the Lord' and used 24 times in the Old Testament. But the word has been left untranslated only four times and found in Rev. 19. The first roar of 'Hallelujah' is in connection with the destruction of the Babylon church, the harlot. The second roar is connected with the fall of the Babylon city the Great. The third shout is joined mainly by 24 elders and the 4 living creatures. The fourth roar is connected with the enthronement of the Son of God and His wedding celebrations. What are they shouting like the roar of rushing waters and like loud peals of thunder? "Our Lord God Almighty reigns. Let us rejoice and be glad and give Him glory! For the wedding of the Lamb has come, and His bride has made herself ready".

Wedding feast of the Lamb:

'Blessed are those who are invited to the wedding supper of the Lamb!' (Rev. 19:9). Who are the invitees? Those who are saved through faith in Jesus Christ during the Great Tribulation and the Old Testament saints are the invitees.

We have studied about two final judgements. Both are connected with Babylon. The Babylon church is pictured as a harlot because it has broken its relationship with Jesus Christ. We must be concerned about the condition of churches at the present time and keep ourselves holy and in the right relationship with our Lord as His spotless Bride.

Questions:

1. Who are the people coming under the final judgements?
2. What is the name carried by Babylon church on their foreheads? Why is she pictured as a harlot?
3. Prove that the Babylon church is the Roman Catholic church and other nominal churches joining it as a union?
4. Identify the beast on which the woman is sitting.
5. What is the judgement that befalls the harlot? Who executes the judgement?
6. How does the city of Babylon fall? Which is this city?
7. Four shouts of 'Hallelujah' are heard in Rev. 19. Which event is each of the shouts associated with?
8. Who is the Bride of the Lamb? Who are the invitees to the wedding feast?
9. Are you a member of the church that will form a part of the Bride of the Lamb? Do you have the love and relationship with the Bridegroom?

LESSON 23

Seven judgements (contd)

War of Armageddon, Millennium and the Last Judgement

Objective: To learn that godless powers will end in pathetic manner and saints of God will rule with Him eternally.

Lesson:

Rev. 19:11 – 20:15

Memory verses: Rev. 20:6

Blessed and holy is he who shares in the first resurrection! Over such the second death has no power, but they shall be priests of God and of Christ, and they shall reign with him a thousand years.

Introduction:

We learnt about two of the last seven judgements in the previous lesson. All the forces that stand against the gospel, whether religious or political, will end pathetically. The kingdom of God will remain eternally. In this lesson, we shall learn about the other five judgements and the Millennium. God's judgements are always just and true.

War of Armageddon and victory of Christ the King:

After the wedding feast, Christ and His Bride, the Church, descend to the earth and confront Antichrist and his army. This scene is described in Rev. 19:11-12. Heaven opens and a white horse appears. The Rider on the horse has eyes like blazing fire and is dressed in a robe dipped in blood. His names are Faithful, True and the Word of God. With justice He judges and makes war. The armies of heaven are following Him, riding on white horses and dressed in fine linen, white and clean. Out of His mouth comes a sharp sword. On His robe and on His thigh, this name is written: KING OF KINGS AND LORD OF LORDS.

As described above, Christ returns to earth as a glorious King along with thousands of saints and angels (Jude 15). His main purpose is the redemption of Israel. Antichrist hears about the arrival of the glorious King on Mount Olives to support Israel at a time when he has destroyed all enemies and is reigning over all nations with absolute power. He directs his army to Jerusalem (Dan. 11:44). He establishes his temporary camp in the plains between Jerusalem and Mediterranean sea. Armies of nations like Gog and Magog line up behind him. Battle of Armageddon begins when Christ and His saints on Mount Olives on the east side of Jerusalem face Antichrist and his forces in the plains on the west side of Jerusalem (Rev. 19:19). There are many prophetic passages about this war: Isa. 63:1-6, Zach. 14:3, 12-14, Ezek. 38:21-23, Isa. 66:6, 2 Thes. 2:8, 1:6-8, Rev. 19:19-21. Christ, the Lion of Judah will sound His thunderous voice. Bodies of armies of Antichrist will melt at the sound. They begin to kill each other. An earthquake tears apart hills and mountains and many die. Rain and hailstones pour down on the armies. Thus the armies of Antichrist will meet their end in the plains on the west of Jerusalem

(Dan. 11:45). Their blood will flow for a distance of 1,600 stadia from the north of Palestine to the south, rising as high as the horses' bridles (approx. 5 feet) (Rev. 14:20). The destruction will be of such a magnitude that has not happened ever before. Thus the followers of Antichrist are punished. Antichrist and his associate, False prophet are cast alive into the Lake of fire. Flesh of those killed will be food for the birds. These are the events associated with the **third and fourth judgements**.

Satan is bound:

After the war of Armageddon, an angel is seen holding the key to the Abyss and a great chain in his hand binding Satan, the serpent and locking him up in the abyss for 1000 years. The judgement of Satan will come after 1000 years. During the millennial rule of Christ, Satan is locked up.

Millennial reign of Christ:

The reign of Jesus Christ on earth for 1000 years is called the Millennial Rule. It is mentioned seven times in the passage, Rev. 20:1-7. There are other passages in the Scriptures that describe the events, nature and the world system during this period without mentioning the exact duration.

Main events:

1. Judgement of the nations (Matt. 25:31-33): The nations are judged according to the way in which they treated Jews during the Great Tribulation. Those who helped them are taken into the kingdom of Christ. Others are cast into eternal fire.
2. The reinstatement of Israel: The whole nation of Israel will accept Jesus Christ as their Lord and Saviour (Rom. 11:26, Zach. 12:10, Isa. 66:6-8). They will all be gathered into their Promised Land (Matt. 24:31, Jer. 3:18-19, 16:15, Ezek. 36:24-25, Amos 9:9).
3. Establishment of the Kingdom of God: Throne of Messiah will be installed in Jerusalem (Matt. 5:35). The saints of God will be invested with royalty and rule (Dan. 7:27). The twelve apostles will sit on twelve thrones and rule over the twelve tribes of Israel (Luke 22: 28-30). Church (saints of God) will reign with Christ with transfigured bodies. People of Israel

and nations that have entered the Millennium will be subjects of the kingdom. No one will do any evil as Satan is chained. The earth will be like the earth before the fall of Adam. Even the animals will not have any tendency to cruelty. Read the prophecies about that kingdom in these passages: Isa. 35:4-10, 11:1-9, 55:13, Jer. 33:6-11, Joel 2:23-27. Let us wait for the second coming of our Lord so that we can reign with Him during those blessed days.

Fifth judgement:

Gog and Magog (Rev. 20:7-10): Satan is released from his bonds at the end of the Millennium. He proceeds to gather a huge army from all corners of the earth to fight against God and His people. This army is led by Gog and Magog. In the previous battle of Armageddon, too, the nations of Gog and Magog were involved (Ezek. 38:1-3, 39:1-2). Gog and Magog represent the communist nations under the control of Russia.

Sixth judgement (Rev. 20:7,10):

Satan and his armies are destroyed by fire. He is thrown into the Lake of Fire where Antichrist and False prophet were thrown earlier. There they will suffer punishment eternally. Thus is the end of Satan.

Seventh judgement (Last judgement) (Rev. 20:11-15):

The Lord appears as a judge on a huge white throne. Heaven and earth flee away from Him. So we can conclude that this throne is installed in the outer space. All those dead without Christ resurrect. They are judged on the basis of the Book of Life. As their names are not found in the Book of Life, they are thrown into the Lake of Fire, which is the second death for them. Thus all judgements come to a close.

The righteous God gives appropriate punishments to 1) the Babylonian church, 2) city of Babylon, 3) followers of Antichrist, 4) Antichrist and false prophet, 5) Gog and Magog, 6) Satan and 7) the evil men who did not resurrect in the first resurrection. He gives appropriate rewards to His people. Hence it is necessary to ponder upon what we are going to receive from the Lord. The Lake of Fire is prepared for Satan and his army. We should not fall into Satan's deception and follow him into the Lake of Fire.

The way to eternal life is through Jesus Christ. Is your name in the Book of Life?

Questions:

1. Describe the battle of Armageddon. How are the armies fighting against Israel destroyed?
 2. Who are punished in the third and fourth judgements?
 3. Describe the main events of the Millennium rule of Christ and the special nature of the period.
 4. No one does any evil during Millennium. Why?
 5. On which occasions do Gog and Magog rise up against Israel? Which nations do they represent?
 6. What is the result of the sixth judgement?
 7. Describe the Last Judgement.
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LESSON 24

Seven New Beginnings

Objective: To learn about the new beginnings prepared for the people of God who received new birth through Jesus Christ and lead a holy life with that blessed hope.

Lesson:

Rev. 21:1 – 22:5

Memory verses: 2 Pet. 3:11-13

Since our things are thus to be dissolved, what sort of persons ought you to be in lives of holiness and godliness, waiting for and hastening the coming of the day of God, because of which the heavens will be kindled and dissolved, and the elements will melt with fire! But according to this promise we wait for new heavens and a new earth in which righteousness dwells.

Introduction:

What do you do when your house becomes uninhabitable for any reason? You will try to build a new house in its place. The earth in which we live has become uninhabitable, cursed, turbulent and ripe for destruction because of man's sin (Isa. 24:4-6, 19-20). Its sin has become heavy for it to bear. It will fall and not get up. The whole creation is waiting eagerly for a new beginning (Rom. 8:20-22). The loving God has planned to make everything new. First of all, He makes every man a new creation through Jesus Christ. Then He is preparing seven new things for the new men in Christ. These are described in the closing chapters of Revelation.

1. New heaven and (2) New earth:

A new age begins with the end of the Millennium and the end of Satan and his hosts. It is necessary that this earth that is cursed because of man's sin and the space enveloping it are renewed. The first earth and heaven will pass away. There will be no more sea, too (Rev. 21:1). We read that by the word of God, the present heavens and earth are reserved for fire, being kept for the day of judgment and destruction of ungodly men (2 Pet. 3:5-7). It is further explained in the following verses: "The heavens will disappear with a roar; the elements will be destroyed by fire, and the earth and everything in it will be laid bare. Since everything will be destroyed in this way, what kind of people ought you to be? You ought to live holy and godly lives as you look forward to the day of God and speed its coming. That day will bring about the destruction of the heavens by fire, and the elements will melt in the heat. But in keeping with his promise we are looking forward to a new heaven and a new earth, the home of righteousness. So then, dear friends, since you are looking forward to this, make every effort to be found spotless, blameless and at peace with him" (2 Pet. 3:10-14). Jesus Christ has also foretold about the passing away of the heaven and the earth (Matt. 24:35). The same thing is prophesied in Isa. 65:17 and Psa. 102:25-26. The surface of the earth and atmosphere around it will be burned by fire and the seas will be

dried up. A new earth and a new firmament will be created where righteousness will dwell. With this, all sorrows, cries, death and suffering disappear for ever. The earth will be filled with justice, holiness and blessings. Let us wait for that blessed experience with holiness and fear of God.

3. New Jerusalem (Holy City) (Rev. 21:2,9,10):

John writes: "I saw the Holy City, the new Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven from God, prepared as a bride beautifully dressed for her husband" (Rev. 21:1). Then in Rev. 21:9-10, an angel tells John, "Come, I will show you the bride, the wife of the Lamb" and shows him the Holy City, Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven from God. Hence we can conclude that New Jerusalem is the dwelling place of the Church, the Bride of Christ. Old Testament saints also will dwell there. Twelve foundations of the City are named after the apostles and twelve gates are named after the tribes of Israel. The omnipotent Lamb is its Temple. The saints of God worship Him, seeing Him face to face. As the City is illuminated by the Lamb, sun and moon are not needed there. This beautiful City made with different kinds of precious stones is the inheritance of the children of God. We will dwell there with our Lord and Master for ever. As the City is made of pure gold, as pure as glass, there is no place for any impurity or uncleanness in it. No one whose name is not found in the Book of Life of the Lamb will enter the City. Think about your position in relation with the Book of Life.

4. New nations:

"The nations will walk by its light, and the kings of the earth will bring their splendor into it" (Rev. 21:24). In the Millennium, there will be people who are saved by the work of Israel and who live a holy life. They will enter into the new earth with transformed bodies and will be the subjects of the kingdom. The saints will rule over them (Luke 22:28-30). There will not be any families.

5. New river:

John sees the river of the water of life, as clear as crystal, flowing from the throne of God and of the Lamb down the middle of the

great street of the City. On each side of the river stands the tree of life, bearing twelve crops of fruit, yielding its fruit every month (Rev. 22:1-2). There are hints about this river in Psa. 46 and Ezek. 47.

6. New trees of life:

Trees of life stand on both sides of the river. The fruits that were denied to Adam and Eve are available now to people who are redeemed by the blood of Jesus Christ. They are the portions of the victors (Rev. 2:7).

7. New throne:

New earth is now the place where the throne of God and the Lamb are established (Rev. 22:3). The perfection that results from the establishment of the abode of God are mentioned in this passage: Fullness of holiness (22:3), fullness of reign (22:3), fullness of worship (22:3), fullness of vision (22:4), fullness of identity (22:4), fullness of daytime (22:4) and fullness of glory (22:5).

Eternity:

There are no biblical evidences to definitely estimate the duration of the age of the new heaven and new earth. It could be fifty thousand years. This age declares that Christ fulfilled the plans that God had in His mind for mankind. He has destroyed all dominion, authority and power and He hands over the kingdom to God the Father (1 Cor. 15:24). As Jesus declared while on earth, He will be glorified "with the glory I had with you before the world began" (John 17:5). We will enter into eternity in heaven as Christ hands over the kingdom to the Father. The events of eternity have not been fully revealed to us. New Jerusalem will be taken to heaven. There we will dwell for ever with Triune God and the multitude of saints. It has been foretold that in the fullness of time, all things in heaven and on earth shall be brought together under one head, even Christ (Eph. 1:10). The same prophecy will thus be fulfilled.

We have learnt about the seven new beginnings that are prepared for God's children and the eternity that is in store for us. Are we waiting for the new beginnings? The redemption of this world is at hand. Let us be awake and raise our heads in preparation.

Questions:

1. What are the new things mentioned in the closing chapters of the book of Revelation?
2. What is 'new heaven' and 'new earth' referring to? What happens to the present heaven and earth?
3. Describe the Holy City of New Jerusalem.
4. Which are the nations dwelling in the new earth?
5. What are the attributes of the new river or the river of the water of life flowing through New Jerusalem?
6. Describe the trees of life on the new earth.
7. Describe the experiences of perfection resulting from the establishment of the Throne of God on the earth. Quote relevant verses.
8. Where will the saints spend their eternity after the age of perfection on the earth?

LESSON 25

Book of Revelation: Conclusion

Objective: To learn about the greatness of the book of Revelation and the importance of its message and to be prepared for the second coming of Jesus Christ.

Lesson:

Rev. 22:4-21

Memory verses:

Rev. 22:12-14

"Behold, I am coming soon, bringing my recompense, to repay everyone for what he has done. I am the Alpha and Omega, the first and the last, the beginning and the end."

Blessed are those who wash their robes that they may have the right to the tree of life and that they may enter the city by the gates.

Introduction:

Where does the story of mankind begin in the Bible? Who was the evil one who drew man into a sinful state, although man was created in the nature of God to live with Him? Which is the book that describes the end of Satan and the completion of man's redemption? Satan and his followers hate the book of Revelation and dissuade man from studying it? On the other hand, it can be seen that God gives a lot of importance to this book. God declares: "Blessed is the one who reads the words of this prophecy, and blessed are those who hear it and take to heart what is written in it, because the time is near" (Rev. 1:3). He also warns: "If anyone adds anything to them, God will add to him the plagues described in this book. And if anyone takes words away from this book of prophecy, God will take away from him his share in the tree of life and in the holy city, which are described in this book" (Rev. 22:19). What is the main message of this book? (Rev. 1:7, 22:7, 12:20). What should be our prayer in this regard? (Rev. 22:20).

Glory of the One who testifies and the trustworthiness of the Word:

The trustworthiness of the Word is emphasized in the closing passages of the book. Holy Spirit knew very well that in the last days even church leaders will rise to discredit this book as someone's dream or imagination. That is why, it is emphatically declared that the Word is trustworthy and true (Rev. 22:6).

Glory of the One who testifies:

1. "I am the Alpha and the Omega, the First and the Last, the Beginning and the End" (Rev. 22:13). The One who testifies to the Word is the omnipotent and eternal Son of God.
2. "I am the Root and the Offspring of David, and the bright Morning Star" (Rev. 22:16). As God, Jesus is the root of David and as man, He is from the tribe of David. He is the Lord of David (Psa. 110:1, Acts 2:34-35, Matt. 22:41-44) and at the same time the Son of David. He is also the Morning Star and the hope of the people of God.

Trustworthiness of the Word:

Look at the other verses that emphasize the trustworthiness of the Word. It is mentioned that “The Lord, the God of the spirits of the prophets, sent his angel to show his servants the things that must soon take place” (Rev. 22:6). The Lord says: “Blessed is he who keeps the words of the prophecy in this book” (Rev. 22:7). Then He declares: “I, Jesus, have sent my angel to give you this testimony for the churches” (Rev. 22:16). It is further emphasized: “If anyone adds anything to them, God will add to him the plagues described in this book. And if anyone takes words away from this book of prophecy, God will take away from him his share in the tree of life and in the holy city, which are described in this book” (Rev. 22:18,19). Hence it is necessary that we accept the messages of the book totally and organize our lives accordingly.

God alone is worthy of worship (Rev. 22:8,9):

Man has a tendency to worship anyone who appears bigger than him. This passage teaches us that it is a wrong tendency and only God should be worshipped. Angels are assigned to serve the children of God. They are not to be worshipped. Similar is the case of other men who may appear bigger or holier. Apostles have also given the same instruction (Acts 10:25-26, 14:12-18). It is wrong to worship saints and angels and make offerings before them.

Main message in the book of Revelation (Rev. 22:10-15):

The Lord repeatedly declares that He is coming soon (Rev. 1:7, 22:7,12,20). This is the central theme of the book. Along with this declaration, we also see a special type of exhortation: “Let him who does right continue to do right; and let him who is holy continue to be holy”. Children of God who are justified through faith in Jesus Christ are exhorted to continue to do right. Those that are made holy through the blood of the Lamb must continue to lead a holy life. They must grow in holiness and righteousness. Read Apostle Paul’s words: “You were taught, with regard to your former way of life, to put off your old self, which is being corrupted by its deceitful desires; to be made new in the attitude of your

minds; and to put on the new self, created to be like God in true righteousness and holiness" (Eph. 4:22-24).

Then why the instruction: "Let him who does wrong continue to do wrong; let him who is vile continue to be vile"? It points to the fact that there is not much time left to repent and be saved. Let us wait earnestly for our soon coming Lord in holiness. Further instruction, "Do not seal up the words of the prophecy of this book, because the time is near" also gives emphasis to the same message.

Free gift of the water of life (Rev. 22:17):

Holy Spirit and the Church invite people to the water of life. Remember how Jesus Christ invited the woman of Samaria and the people of Israel to the water of life (John 4:10, 7:37). Holy Spirit is the promise of free gift of water of life to us in the end times. The Lord will satisfy us with this gift if we wait for it at His feet. What is your experience?

Last words of 'Amen':

The Bridegroom, Christ says, "I am coming soon". To this, the Bride replies with joy: "Amen. Come, Lord Jesus". Then after the benediction, both Bridegroom and Bride join to say, 'Amen' and the scene ends.

Eternal heaven and eternal hell:

Book of Revelation reveals two eternities. Children of God saved by faith in the supreme sacrifice of Jesus Christ on the cross and who live a holy life on the earth will be with the Lord eternally in heaven. But those who neglect God's love and live their own way will spend their eternity in the lake of fire. Have you made sure of your eternity? Have you taken the decision to accept Jesus as your Lord and Saviour, be baptized according to the Word of God and live a Spirit-filled, holy life on the earth? Then you will be able to live a blessed, peaceful and joyful life both now and for ever.

Questions:

1. Where does the story of mankind begin and end?
2. When is the enemy of mankind, Satan, defeated? How?
3. What is the most important message of the book of Revelation?
4. Prove that the words in the book are trustworthy and true.
5. Describe the two types of eternity.

LESSON 26

World Religions

Objective: To learn about other religions of the world so as to be prepared to approach others with the gospel of Christ.

Lesson:

Gen. 4:3-5, 25-26,
10:6-10

Memory verses:

Rom. 1:19,20

For what can be known about God is plain to them, because God has showed to them. Ever since the creation of the world his invisible nature, namely, his eternal power and deity, has been clearly perceived in the things that have been made.

Introduction:

What is the 'Great Commission' given by our Lord as recorded in Mark 16:15? We are commanded to preach the gospel to all nations in the world. Do you have the experience of visiting homes alone or with others to share the gospel with them? Have you seen the reaction of people belonging to other religions? Some people may question the idea of salvation through Christ. So it will

be useful to know their religious views to explain the message of salvation to them. The message of salvation through Christ may be hidden in the philosophy of certain religions. You must try to find out about the faith and beliefs of your neighbours. We should never keep any feeling of hatred to others on the basis of their religious beliefs. So let us study briefly about other religions.

Main religions of India:

Religious beliefs are formed on the basis of hearing, reasoning and experience. In other words, religions are basically conclusions formed by intelligent man in his quest for finding God and pleasing Him to obtain His blessings. Although people who believe in Christ are usually referred to as belonging to Christian religion, Christ did not establish any religion. The word 'religion' is not applicable to the way of Christ. Religions followed in India are Hinduism, Islam, Buddhism, Jainism, Sikhism, Parsi and Jewish faiths.

Origin of religions in the world:

The beginning of gentile religions can be traced to ancient Babylon. After the Great Flood, Noah's children began to multiply. Although Noah brought up his children in the fear of God, people began to lose their faith in course of time. They built a city in the plains of Shinar and began building a tower reaching the heavens. As their intention to make a name for themselves and stay together in one place was contrary to His will, God confused their language and scattered them to different places (Gen. 11:1-9). Nimrod, the grandson of Noah was the leader who attempted the building project. Ancient history says that Nimrod founded the city of Babel and Babylonian religion. He was a mighty warrior (Gen. 10:8-10) and emperor of Babylon. He came to be known as incarnation of sun god and his image began to be worshipped. He was later killed by descendants of Shem. His wife, Queen Semiravis took control of the kingdom and the religion. Her son Ninas was considered as Nimrod born again. People began worship of all three, Nimrod, Ninas and Semiravis. Excavations have found idols of Semiravis holding baby Ninas. Idol worship spread to various

parts of the world. Gods and goddesses sprang up in different names: Semiravis, Astheroth, Arthemis, Diana, Venus, Sybili, Seerus (all goddesses), Nimrod, Ninas, Baal, Thammus, Dagon, Bacccus, Ossirus, Janus and Melok (all gods). The idols known at the time of Jesus on earth in the Roman empire, India and other nations are all variations of these gods and goddesses. Even Israel was attracted by these idols at various times. When Emperor Constantine and his followers embraced Christianity without experiencing real conversion in the beginning of the 4th century, idol worship spread into Christian groups also.

Some religions that came up afterwards have raised their voices against idol worship. But the influence of the Babylonian religion is still quite prevalent. The fall of Babylonian religion is described in Rev. 18. Read Rev. 18:4: "Then I heard another voice from heaven say: "Come out of her, my people, so that you will not share in her sins, so that you will not receive any of her plagues"

Questions:

1. Which are the main religions in India?
2. What is a religion?
3. Where is the origin of the religions of the world?
4. How did the worship of Semiramis holding baby Ninas begin?
5. What are the other names of Semiramis?
6. What are the other names of Nimrod (Ninas)?
7. Quote the verse from Revelation asking people to come out of Babylonian religion.

LESSON 27

Hinduism

Objective: To learn about Hinduism, the main religion of India and to prepare ourselves to share the gospel with our Hindu brothers.

Lesson:

Rom. 1:14-23,
Acts 17:21-31

Memory verses: Rom. 1:16-17

For I am not ashamed of the gospel: it is the power of God for salvation to everyone who has faith, to the Jew first and also to the Greek. For in it the righteousness of God has revealed through faith for faith; and it is written, "He who through faith is righteous shall live."

Introduction:

The land of India stretches from Kanyakumari to Kashmir and 83% of our population follow Hindu religion. Only 3% of our population are known as Christians. Gospel is the power of God unto salvation of all people. Gospel is centered on Jesus Christ and His atoning death. India has a rich heritage of culture and spirituality. If we study ancient scriptures like *Vedas* and *Upanishads* written by ancient Hindu saints who were seekers after truth, we will discover messages that were given by God for man's salvation. Therefore, all Indians must try to obtain a basic knowledge about the teachings of Hindu religion.

The historical background of Hindu religion:

The word 'Hindu' is connected with the river Sindhu (Indus). People who traveled from Babylon (West Asia) eastwards reached India and settled on the banks of Sindhu river. They came to be known as Hindus and the land was called Hindusthan (India). Read Esther 1:1. The names, Hindu and India came to be associated

with the country, its people and its religion. Modern Hinduism has evolved through the influence of many cultural and religious thoughts during the last 5000 years. So we cannot say when Hinduism began or who established that religion. Hindus numbering 525 millions, who are spread over the land from Kanyakumari to Kashmir and from Punjab to Assam worship many different gods and goddesses and follow different traditions. There is no single religious philosophy or tradition that is common to all Hindus.

Six periods of Hindu history:

1. Period before the arrival of Aryans (B.C. 5000-2000): We learn about the culture of that period from the cultural traditions of Sindhu region which can be found from the relics of cities like Mohan-jo-daro and Harappa. Those were similar to the traditions of Babylon that we studied in the previous lesson.
2. Period of the Vedas (B.C. 2000-600): After the arrival of Aryans, a mixed culture of Aryans and the Dravidians came into being. Vedas written by Aryans were accepted by people. Four main Vedas are: Rigveda, Samaveda, Yajurveda and Atharvaveda. Four castes, Brahmins, Kshatriyas, Vysyas and Soodras came into being at this time. Brahmins became a dominant group.
3. Period of intellectuals and rebellion (B.C. 600 - A.D. 300): Intellectuals began questioning Brahmin domination, caste separation and animal sacrifices. Epics like Mahabharat, Ramayan were written at this time. Reformist ideas from Buddhism and Jainism began to spread and Brahminism began to lose strength.
4. Period of reforms (A.D. 300-1200): Acceptance of ideas from Buddhism and Jainism after A.D. 300 led to reformation in Hindu religion. For that reason, Buddhism and Jainism started declining in India.
5. Rise of Islam (A.D. 1200-1757): India could not withstand the onslaught of Muslim rulers from West Asia. India came

under the rule of Muslims and many people were compelled to convert to Islam. The situation continues even today.

6. Modern times (A.D. 1757 onwards): Arrival of western rulers, work of Christian missionaries and modern education have awakened Indian population and brought improvements in Hinduism. Practice of Sati and many blind observances have been abolished. Prominent teachers like Swami Vivekananda, Shri Sankaracharya and Shri Ramakrishna Paramahansa have brought about spiritual revival in Hinduism and high position among world religions. But Hindus have not yet realized that the truth that the Vedas and Upanishads were seeking for can be found in Jesus Christ.

Hindu religious scriptures:

No single book is recognized as religious scripture of Hindus like the Bible of Christians or Khuran of Muslims. But there are many books written at different periods of time that have been traditionally accepted as religious scriptures.

Four Vedas:

1. **Rigveda:** This is the most ancient of the Vedas authored by rishis of nine generations between B.C. 1000 and 600. There are about 1000 poems in 10 sections. The initial sections are about praising gods associated with natural forces like sun, moon, wind, fire, etc. In the 10th section, a single god called Prajapathy appears. Thus it can be seen that the thinking of Aryans has progressed from many gods to a single god. Prajapathy is described in 'Purushasooktham'. 'Prajapathy' means master of creation. The poem says that the person, Prajapathy is a sacrificial offering and when cow is sacrificed, it should be taken as equivalent to sacrifice of Prajapathy.

2. **Samaveda:** This is the second veda that was written after Rigveda. 'Sama' means song. Except for 75 incantations, the remaining verses are all condensed from Rigveda.

3. **Yajurveda:** This volume is mostly verses to be used for sacrificial offerings. War between gods and demons and snake

worship are also described in the book. Siva, Rudra, Sankar and other names are also found here. Prajapathy has a prominent place in the writings.

4. Adharvaveda: This is a later veda written by Rishi Adharva. Marriage rituals, medicinal details, etc. are described in the book.

Epics: There are two main epics: Ramayan and Mahabharatha.

Ramayan: This is the story of Sriram, the king of Ayodhya. Sriram is considered the incarnation of Vishnu. The epic is believed to have been written by Rishi Valmiki in around 300 B.C. Ten headed Ravana was probably a king ruling South India and Srilanka. Ramayan is the story of the war between Sriram and Ravana. The superiority of Aryans over Dravidians is portrayed in the story.

Mahabharatha: The story is about the battle between two sections of a royal family, namely, between Pandavas and Kauravas.

Srikrishna was on the side of Pandavas in the battle. The advices that Srikrishna gave to Arjuna (a Pandava) during the battle have been compiled into a volume, called Bhagavad Geetha. The principles found in the book are accepted as basic religious teachings by Hindus.

From the details that you have studied about Hindu scriptures in this lesson, what do you think is the main difference between them and the Bible? Although the 66 books of the Bible were written during a long period of time, the contents are similar in nature and about the redemption of mankind through Jesus Christ. Some Hindu scriptures talk about belief in one God, eternal nature of human soul, sinful nature of man, sacrifice for pardon of sins, salvation, etc. Some other scriptures talk in contrary terms to these truths. We should try to deal with our Hindu brothers with this knowledge and point to them Christ who is the Saviour of mankind.

Questions:

1. How did Hindu religion get its name?
 2. Which are the six stages of development of Hindu religion?
 3. Name the four Vedas. What are the main contents of the Vedas?
 4. Which are the two main epics?
 5. What is the content of Bhagavat Geetha? Whose advices are described and to whom they are given? In what circumstances?
 6. Compare Bible and books of Hindu religion.
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LESSON 28

World Religions - Hindu Religion (Hinduism) Contd....

Objective: To understand the important ideas of Hindu religious texts and modern trends, and be equipped for sharing gospel with the Hindus.

Lesson:

Acts of the Apostles
17:22-31;
1 Corinthians 1:8-15

Memory verses:

Acts of the Apostles 17:29-30

Being then God's of offering, we ought not to think that the Deity is like gold, or silver, or stone, a representation by the art and imagination of man. The times of ignorance God over looked, but now he commands all men everywhere to repent

Introduction:

Before preaching the Gospel in Athens, Apostle Paul walked around to see the manners and customs of the people in that place (Act. 17:23). Are we indebted to share the Gospel with our Hindu brothers? As we relate with them, we need to understand

the important teachings of their religious texts and also the modern thought patterns among them. We have already studied about the different texts of the Hindus in the previous lesson. Which is the most ancient among them? Most of the people accepted the ideas of the Upanishads and puranas, and the books of modern writers. Lets, study something about these things:

Important teaching of Upanishads

The teachings of Upanishads, which was written as an appendix to the Vedas, were neither unified nor systematic. There are even contradictory ideas among them. The significant aspect in Upanishads is the monotheistic in faith. The basic cause and supreme authority of everything is the Brahman Ishwara or Paramatma. Brahman is invisible, formless, omnipresent, almighty and eternal. This thought is not different from Israelite or Christian revelation. But there are verses that give different opinions about the personality of God in the Chandogya Upanishad, Brahman, Jeeva, Prakriti are stated differently. 'Jagat' is living in Ishwara, and Upanishad never says that 'Jagat' is Ishwara. Still, it says that Brahman is the supreme spirit, life is one portion of the Brahman, finally, it may dissolve in Brahman and be at bliss. So generally speaking Upanishads have an affinity with Advaita. Most of the Hindus understand God as an invisible, and omnipresent power. The Advaitic people cannot believe a God who intervenes in Human life or nature, or as one who answers the individual prayers that we offer. The two words of 'Thatvamsi' and 'Aham Brahmasmi' as seen in Chandogya Upanishad and Brahadaranyaka are adopted by Sri Sankara for his advaitic Philosophy. But the Brahman Sutras of Badarayana (the writer of Maha Bharata, Vyasa) made it clear that Brahman and Jeeva are two different entities. Not only that universe is the creation of Brahman and Brahman is not simply without attributes, he explained. The teaching of life after death (rebirth) is scattered in the Upanishads. There is clear form to this. For Mukti, one needs Brahmanjñana and Karma, and one who gets mukti, makes a long journey after the death, this is what Upanishad teaches.

Puranas

The Thrimurtis, Brahman, Vishnu and Maheshwara are described as the three visible images of Brahman. Brahman is the creator of all, Vishnu is the sustainer, and Shiva is the destroyer of the people who have completed their lives in respective times.

The history of the 9th incarnation of Vishnu among the ten incarnations is the main description of Puranas.

Bagavat Gita

Bagavat Gita is the important section of Maha Bharata. Contains several foundational Philosophies and doctrines. Brahman is omnipresent and the main cause of everything. Everything begins and ends with Brahman. The part of Iswara with Human being is known as Atman (Jeevatman). The destiny of each life (Jeeva) is to dissolve the part of divinity, the spirit in Paramatma. Those who do the good works can dissolve their life in Paramatma. This is the Moksha. Those who did not get their divine status, their spirits go through the cycle of rebirth till they reach that state. They may get either the higher or lower experiences according to the works they are doing in each life 'Maya' is hindrance to the Mukti of the soul. The way to get Mukti out of Maya, is 'tapas' to get out of maya acquisition of knowledge and yoga are advised. Any one who has a real devotion, to anything or, having any faith will get Mukti. Ahimsa (non-violence) is the supreme charity.

The Advaita of Sree-Sankaracharya

The most important among the modern ideologies of Hindus is the Advaita of Sri Sankaracharya. Iswara (Paramatma) is not different from creatures or Nature, Aham Brahmasmi, Thatvamasi are the basic foundation. It means, "I am Brahman, and you also." Both murderer and one who is murdered are Brahman. In Advaita, there is no concept of sin. This world is not real, and Brahman is truth. World and everything in it are unreal. Brahman is formless, non-attitude, and indefinable. Swami Vivekananda also taught almost there unreal. Everything is Brahman. This is not far from Atheism.

The Monotheistic faith of Sri Ramanuja

Ramanuja who lived in A.D. 1027 to 1117 challenged the teaching of Sankara, Iswara as without attribute and called the people to a God that is with attributes. He was strong Vaishnava prophet.

Arya Samaj, Brahma Samaj, Sree Ramakrishna Mission

Arya samaj, Brahma Samaj, Sree Rama Krishna Mission are the social organisations formed among Hindus to eradicate the superstitions among Hindu Society and to work for the overall development of the Community. They are doing several good things for the social upliftment.

Conclusion

You have already learned the teachings of Hindu religions texts and the modern trends among Hindus. What did you understand from this? Is there any generally accepted Philosophy or faith foundation for Hindu Religion? There are contradictory ideas in different texts.

Questions

1. What are Upanishads? What is the short coming for their teachings?
2. What is the teaching of Upanishad and Brahman?
3. Why do we say that Upanished teachings are related of Advaita?
4. Which are the three visible forms of Brahman described in Puranas?
5. Which are the important ideas in Bhagavat Gita?
6. What is the Advaita Philosophy of Sree Sankara? Is it acceptable? If not, why?
7. What is the faith of Sree Ramanuja?
8. Which are the social organisation working for the reformation of Hindu Society?

LESSON 29

World Religions - Islam

Objective: To learn about Islam and realize how superior is faith in Christ for the salvation of man.

Lesson:

Heb. 1:1 – 2:4

Memory verses:

Heb. 1:1-2

In many and various ways God spoke of old to our Fathers by the prophets; but in these lase days he has spoken to us by a Son, who he appointed the heir of all things, through whome he created the world.

Introduction:

While other religions talk about man's feverish attempts to know about God and attain salvation through rituals and works, gospel reveals a God who loves man and came looking for him. Which is the second largest religion in India after Hinduism? Islam. Let us learn a few things about Islam.

Founder:

Islam founder Mohammed Nabi was born in A.D. 570 in Mecca. He was faithful, merciful and god-fearing from his childhood. Arabs in those days were idol worshippers and slaves to many wrong rituals. In addition, young Mohammed also found a spiritually and socially decadent Christian church.

The Christian church under the patronage of Roman emperors was spiritually dead. Fighting for leadership was the order of the day. There was intense competition between the western church under the western Roman rulers and the eastern church under

the eastern Roman authority. There were also quarrels about doctrines of the church. Young Mohammed was disenchanted with both the Christians and the Jews. He married Kadeeja, a rich and older widow at the age of 25.

It is believed that he got divine revelations through angel Gabriel at the age of 40. He began to declare divine messages about need for faith in one God to people around him, denouncing idol worship and other social evils prevalent in Arabia. Thus began 'Islam', meaning 'dedication to will of God'. As his teaching was vehemently opposed by people of Mecca, he was compelled to move to a more favourable place, Medina in A.D. 622. This year is considered the beginning year of Islam and known as Hajira, meaning 'exodus' or 'migration'. He died in A.D. 632. By that time Islam religion and Islamic rule were established in Arabia. After his death, Caliphs ruled Arabia as heads of religion and state. In 100 years' time, Christian strongholds like Jerusalem, Syria, Palestine, Egypt Persia, North Africa and Spain came under Islamic control. Spiritual decline of Christian church is the root cause of the rise of Islam. Rulers used military forces to convert people to Islamic religion. Baghdad was the capital of Islamic rule from A.D. 750 to 1258. Islam spread in India after Muslim rulers from West Asia invaded India.

Religious book:

Koran is the authoritative religious scripture of Islam. Muslims believe that it is the divine revelation given to Mohammed by Allah through Gabriel. They say that the Law (Torah) given to Moses, Psalms (Saboor) given to David and Gospels (Ingeel) given to Jesus were changed by Jews and Christians and hence cannot be believed in their present forms. Another book that they accept as a religious writing is 'Suttha' which records the words and deeds of Mohammed Nabi.

Basic tenets:

There is one God. He is all powerful, all knowing and creator of all. All events are fore ordained by Him. Jesus Christ is accepted as a prophet. They cannot accept the idea that He is the Son of

God. They do not accept the fundamental Christian teaching that all have sinned because of Adamic sin and that man can get salvation and eternal life by putting faith in the death of Jesus on the cross. They believe in a final judgement when those righteous men who live according to Islamic rules will enter into the happiness of Paradise and others will be sent to hell. So entry into Paradise is based on one's works and rituals according to Islamic teaching. On the other hand, Christian gospel proclaims that salvation is free and by grace of God through faith.

Rituals for salvation:

1. Declaration of faith: A Muslim must declare his faith publicly. We can hear this declaration from mosques at the time of prayer. The repetition of: "Allah is the greatest; There is no other god other than Allah; Mohammed is god's prophet" in Arabic is considered a good deed.

2. Prayer: A believer has to pray at five specified times in a day. In addition, all must gather in a mosque for prayer together on Friday.

3. Fast: A believer has to observe fast every day from sunrise to sunset during the month of Ramzan. One can eat in the night.

4. Sakkat (Alms): Giving of alms to poor, orphans and old people is compulsory. Special alms must be given in Ramzan.

5. Haj: A believer must make a pilgrimage to Mecca at least once in his lifetime. He must start on the pilgrimage only after special preparations. He must go round 'Kaba' in Mecca seven times. A lamb or a camel must also be sacrificed

In addition to the above 5, there are many other rituals too.

Islam religion and Christian gospel:

There are some references in Koran to biblical events and doctrines. Muslims accept Noah, Abraham, Moses, David and other Old Testament characters as prophets. But they were always against Jews and Christians from the beginning. The main aim of Mohammed and his followers was to establish their religion and

their rule. Islam urges its followers to wage 'Jihad' or 'holy war'. There is no ban on using weapons to achieve their goal.

Man under the bondage of sin and death cannot be redeemed by rituals or pilgrimages. But the transformation that the love of God as displayed through Jesus Christ can bring about in man is truly amazing. Let us display that love and holiness in our lives and attract our Muslim brothers to the truths of the gospel.

LESSON 30

World Religions (Contd)

Objective: There are many other religions in India. As Paul said that he is indebted to Greeks and the Gentiles, wise and the foolish, we should also be prepared to share the gospel to people of all religions in our land.

Lesson:

1:1-32

Memory verses:

Rom. 1: 14-16

I am under obligation both to Greeks and to barbarians, both to the wise and to the foolish: so I am eager to preach the gospel to you also who are in Rome.

Introduction:

1. Sikh religion:

Most Sikhs are found in north Indian states like Punjab, Hariyana, Uttar Pradesh and Delhi. The founder of Sikh religion was Guru Nanak. As Islam spread in North India, many Hindu pundits were attracted by its teachings like faith in one God, brotherhood, etc. They incorporated those teachings into Hindu

religion and started the Sikh religion. Sikhs were led by 9 gurus after Guru Nanak. All the teachings are recorded in 'Grandhsaheb'. They started carrying a sword ('Kripan') to escape the persecution by the Muslim rulers. Sikhs can be distinguished by five objects:

1. Hair: They grow long hair and tie it above their head and cover it with a turban.
2. Comb: A comb is kept inside the turban.
3. Shorts: Shorts are worn inside the outer dress.
4. Bangle: A steel bangle is worn on the hand.
5. Sword (Kripan): They are instructed to carry a sword. (One section is against carrying a sword).

Sikhs are generally brave, healthy and industrious. Sadhu Sunder Singh was a Sikh, born and brought up in Punjab. Sikhs are generally friendly to Christian teachings. There are many Christian missionaries working among them nowadays.

Golden Temple built in the middle of water in Amritsar is the most important worship place of Sikhs. They have temples called 'Gurudwara' in many parts of the world. Sikhs are instructed to read and follow the teachings in 'Grandhsaheb' and lead a good, moral life. Let us be ready to share the gospel with our Sikh brothers.

2. Parsi religion (Zoroastrian religion):

Parsi religion is an ancient religion from 6th century B.C. Its founder is Zoroastrian who lived in West Asia. Their religious book is 'Amesatha' (Knowledge). They teach that there is a war going on between good and evil and man has the freedom to choose any. They teach that there is an end to history when the dead will rise and pass through a bridge of judgement. Good people will easily pass the bridge and enter heaven. Evil ones will fall into hell. They wait for a saviour. They have many rituals to follow. Dead bodies are not burnt or buried. The bodies are kept on top of 'silent tower' to be eaten by birds. In a few places, dead bodies are electrically cremated. There are many rich Parsi industrialists

in Mumbai. Their fore-fathers migrated to Mumbai from Persia to escape Muslim persecution. There are many similarities between their teachings and Christian teachings. More than 120,000 Parsis live in Mumbai and Gujarat.

3. Buddhist religion:

The founder was Buddha, born as Siddharth in B.C. 503 to Sudhodana, the king of Kapilavastu. Troubled by seeing great sufferings in the world, Siddharth left his home and country and began a penance. He got spiritual enlightenment at the age of 35. He became Buddha from then on and spent his life spreading 'dharma'. He died at the age of 80. His main teachings are as follows:

Sufferings come because one is born. Reason for suffering is greed. Hence to escape from suffering, one must suppress greed and be generous with their wealth. Buddha does not believe in a God who controls the universe. The aim of life is 'moksha', but it is not clear what happens to man after 'moksha'. Buddhist religion does not offer a solution to any of man's problems nor any hope to man. Buddhism has declined in India, but it is a major religion in eastern countries like Japan, China and Srilanka.

4. Jain religion:

The founder was Vardhaman Mahavir, born in B.C. 599 in Magadha. He left his family at the age of 30 and became a 'sanyasi'. He used to wear dress for one and a half years, but lived naked for the rest of his life. He got 'enlightenment' after 13 years. Then he began to teach people that one can attain 'moksha' by self-inflicted physical torture. After his death in B.C. 527, his followers began to worship him as god. Jainism's main teaching is 'Ahimsa paramo dharma'. No creature should be killed or harmed. Jainism may be the reason for the popularity of 'Ahimsa' in India. The aim of life is to free man's soul from 'karma'. The way of escape from the endless cycle of rebirth is through rigorous disciplining of the body like penance, self inflicted torture, self control, obedience, meditation and acquiring of knowledge.

There are not more than 20 lakhs of Jains in India. But they are a small community with great wealth and influence. They are the most literate group after the Parsis. They are willing to learn about principles of other religions. Let us be prepared to share the gospel with them.

Conclusion:

Study of other religions is very extensive. We have dwelt with it only very briefly. All religions are aware of the miserable condition of man. Many accept the reason for such a state as man's sin. But what is the remedy? Man's need is, not a set of principles, but a Saviour. That Saviour has to lift man from the miry clay into which he is sinking. Here is the superiority of the gospel which presents a loving and almighty God who took the form of man and carried all the sins and curses of mankind. Our punishment was taken by Him. Those who put their trust in Him get remission from sin, eternal life and victory over sin. While other religions give importance to the works of man and religious rituals, Christian faith gives importance to the love of God and His grace. Other religions are products of man's wisdom and knowledge. But the gospel has come out of the heart of God. Man should stop trying to attain salvation through his own ways and accept the only way, the truth and the life through Jesus Christ to live a godly life. Let us try to win our friends from other religions by showing love and sharing with them the true way of salvation.

Questions:

1. Which are the main religions in India?
2. Briefly state the history and teachings of Islam.
3. Give the names of the founders of Sikh, Parsi, Buddha and Jain religions. Describe their life story briefly.
4. Explain how Christian gospel is different from the teachings of other religions.
5. Do you believe in the gospel? If you believe, give your reasons.